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ZODIACAL CODEX

*The twelve signs as a map of character, of the body and of
inner work*

VILLUMINATIONS

Fine edition, 2026

Original work · First edition, 2026
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ABOUT THIS WORK

Zodiacal Codex is an original work by Villuminations, written and typeset entirely for **villuminations.com**. Original work · First edition, 2026.

The material it starts from belongs to the **common tradition**: the classical astrological correspondences, the planetary rulers, the division into elements and modalities and the tables of decans have been transmitted in writing for more than two millennia and are nobody's property. What is offered here —the writing, the structure of nine keys, the four-week practices, the reading of body and habit for each sign, the sign entries, the record-keeping exercises and the illustrations — is original work and is protected as such.

No text by any modern author is reproduced here. Where an idea comes from a specific source, the chapter itself says so.

How to read this book. The astrology practised here is a *symbolic language*: an old and very finely tuned way of naming temperaments, tensions and cycles. It is not a predictive science. Nothing that follows announces future events, diagnoses illnesses or replaces the care of a registered doctor, psychologist or dietitian. The guidance on food, sleep and movement is common sense and has to be adapted to your case; if you have a medical condition, a pregnancy or an ongoing treatment, check it first with your health professional.

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CHAPTER 1

BEFORE OPENING THE WHEEL

This book is not going to tell you what is going to happen. It is going to do something more useful: give you a language for observing yourself.

The traditional astrology gathered here is a symbolic system with more than two thousand years of history. It was born as a way of ordering the year, the body and character into twelve recognisable categories, and it survived because those categories describe the perennial human tensions well: impulse and patience, speech and silence, giving and the limit. It is a map of temperament, not a timetable of the future.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS

- A treatise on the twelve signs with their complete classical correspondences: element, modality, polarity, ruler, metal, stone, colour and bodily zone.
- An honest psychological portrait of each sign, with its strengths and with its shadows — because a sign with no shadow is advertising, not description.
- The complete table of the thirty-six decans, with dates and ruler, which is the part of the system that explains why so many people do not recognise themselves in the general description of their sign.

- The four essential dignities sign by sign, with the exact degree of each exaltation and each fall.
- The sixty Egyptian terms—five unequal stretches per sign—which are the finest and most forgotten table of the classical system.
- The division into twenty-eight lunar mansions, with its exact arithmetic and with an honest explanation of why the lists of names do not agree between traditions.
- The precession of the equinoxes with its real figures, the difference between the tropical and the sidereal zodiac and where the «ages» come from.
- The doctrine of sect—day and night charts—which Hellenistic astrology used and the modern kind let drop.
- Melothesia: the traditional distribution of the body among the twelve signs, developed sign by sign as twelve zones of maintenance.
- The geometry of the wheel—opposition, trine, square, sextile—and the six axes of opposite signs explained one by one.
- The system of planetary days and hours, with the arithmetic that explains where the order of the week you use every day came from.
- A dimension of food and habit that hardly any treatise develops, written in terms of compensating for patterns and not of superstition.
- A twelve-month programme of inner work, with one concrete practice per sign, the lunar cycle as its frame and a record for writing down what you observe.
- Seven plates drawn for this book and a closing vocabulary so that you can read any other treatise without getting lost.

WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT

It is not a manual of prediction, it does not calculate birth charts and it promises no results. Nor is it a medical or psychological text: when these pages speak of the body, they speak of habits of care, not of diagnoses or treatments. If something hurts, the answer is in a consulting room, not in a sign.

HOW TO READ IT

You can read it all at once to have the complete map, or go straight to your sign. But the greatest benefit lies in the use the third part proposes: going through the twelve signs over the course of a year, a month for each, working on the quality that belongs to it. Nobody is only their sun sign; we all carry the twelve inside, some of them developed and others asleep.



One last warning, and it is meant seriously. If you use this system to excuse yourself —«I'm like this because I'm a Scorpio»— you have turned it into a cage and you will have wasted your time. The sign describes the raw material you work with, not the sentence. Everything that follows is written for the opposite: so that you recognise your pattern and then decide what you do with it.

CHAPTER 2

THE WHEEL AND ITS FOUR ELEMENTS

The zodiacal wheel is not a list of twelve loose categories. It is a structure with three classifications that cross one another, and understanding that crossing is worth more than memorising the twelve signs separately.

THE FOUR ELEMENTS: THE MATTER OF TEMPERAMENT

Each sign belongs to an element, and the element describes what its energy is made of before any other consideration.

THE FOUR ELEMENTS

FIRE	Aries, Leo, Sagittarius · Impulse, initiative, enthusiasm, heat
EARTH	Taurus, Virgo, Capricorn · Form, constancy, result, body
AIR	Gemini, Libra, Aquarius · Idea, relation, word, distance
WATER	Cancer, Scorpio, Pisces · Emotion, memory, bond, depth

	CARDINAL	FIXED	MUTABLE
FIRE	♈ Aries	♌ Leo	♐ Sagittarius
EARTH	♑ Capricorn	♉ Taurus	♍ Virgo
AIR	♎ Libra	♒ Aquarius	♊ Gemini
WATER	♋ Cancer	♏ Scorpio	♓ Pisces

PL. 4 The twelve cells: four elements by three modalities. No combination repeats, and there lies the reason the system works as a classification.

The elements arrange themselves in two natural pairs. Fire and Air are expansive: they go outwards, they communicate, they spend themselves quickly. Earth and Water are receptive: they accumulate, they conserve, they are slow to start moving and slow to stop. Almost every conflict of living together you will see described in this book comes out of that difference of pace, not out of ill will.

THE THREE MODALITIES: HOW THAT ENERGY MOVES

THE THREE MODALITIES

CARDINAL	Aries, Cancer, Libra, Capricorn · They initiate. They open a season
FIXED	Taurus, Leo, Scorpio, Aquarius · They sustain. They hold the centre
MUTABLE	Gemini, Virgo, Sagittarius, Pisces · They adapt. They close and transform

Modality explains why two signs of the same element behave so differently. Aries, Leo and Sagittarius are the three of Fire, but Aries lights, Leo keeps the flame and Sagittarius hands it round. The element says «what»; the modality says «how».

THE TWO POLARITIES: WHICH WAY IT POINTS

The third classification alternates sign by sign around the wheel. The signs of Fire and Air are traditionally called active or diurnal: their natural movement goes from the inside towards the world. Those of Earth and Water are receptive or nocturnal: their movement goes from the world towards the inside.

THE CROSSING IS WHAT INDIVIDUALISES

Twelve signs = four elements × three modalities. No combination repeats, and that is why the system works as a classification: each sign is the only one occupying its cell. Capricorn is the only Cardinal Earth, Scorpio the only Fixed Water. When you are in doubt about the nature of a sign, rebuild its cell and it will come out on its own.



THE WHEEL AS A YEAR AND AS A PROCESS

The sequence of the twelve signs describes a complete cycle, and that is the key that turns the zodiac into a working tool. It begins in Aries with pure impulse—the seed breaking through the soil—, it gains body in Taurus, it becomes conscious in Gemini, it turns inward in Cancer. It reaches full expression in Leo, it is refined in Virgo, it opens to the other in Libra, it is transformed in Scorpio. It looks for meaning in Sagittarius, it gives it structure in Capricorn, it shares it in Aquarius and it dissolves it in Pisces so that Aries can begin again.



PL. 5 The complete wheel. Outer ring: the twelve signs with their glyph and their element colour. Middle ring: the modality (C, F, M). Inner ring: the sigil of the ruling planet. At the centre, the four elements in a cross.

Read this way, the zodiac stops being a birth label and becomes an itinerary. That is exactly the use the third part of this book proposes.

CHAPTER 3

THE SEVEN TRADITIONAL RULERS

Before the telescope, astrology worked with the seven bodies visible to the naked eye. This book stays inside that classical system for a practical reason: it is coherent, closed and directly usable, and the correspondences of metal, stone and organ you will see in every chapter are built on it.

THE SEVEN AND WHAT THEY RULE

SUN	Leo · Gold · Identity, vitality, heart
MOON	Cancer · Silver · Memory, rhythm, stomach
MERCURY	Gemini and Virgo · Quicksilver · Word, analysis, nervous system
VENUS	Taurus and Libra · Copper · Worth, bond, kidney and throat
MARS	Aries and Scorpio · Iron · Impulse, desire, blood and muscle
JUPITER	Sagittarius and Pisces · Tin · Meaning, expansion, liver
SATURN	Capricorn and Aquarius · Lead · Limit, time, bone and skin

SLOWEST		
•	♄ Saturn Lead · Capricorn and Aquarius	♎ ♊
•	♃ Jupiter Tin · Sagittarius and Pisces	♏ ♓
•	♂ Mars Iron · Aries and Scorpio	♈ ♏
•	☉ Sun Gold · Leo	♌
•	♀ Venus Copper · Taurus and Libra	♉ ♎
•	☿ Mercury Quicksilver · Gemini and Virgo	♊ ♍
•	☾ Moon Silver · Cancer	♋
FASTEST		

PL. 6 The seven rulers in Chaldean order, from Saturn—the slowest in its apparent course—to the Moon. On the right, the signs each one rules. This order also governs the decans and the planetary hours.

WHY EACH PLANET RULES TWO SIGNS

The Sun and the Moon rule one sign each: they are the two luminaries and they do not divide themselves. The other five rule two, one of a diurnal and one of a nocturnal nature, and that double rulership explains kinships that otherwise look arbitrary.

- Mercury in Gemini speaks and connects; in Virgo it orders and refines. The same intelligence, first outwards and then inwards.

- Venus in Taurus enjoys and possesses; in Libra it harmonises and shares. The same sense of worth, first in matter and then in relation.
- Mars in Aries attacks head-on; in Scorpio it persists in silence. The same force, first visible and then underground.
- Jupiter in Sagittarius looks for a horizon; in Pisces it looks for compassion. The same impulse towards meaning, first towards the far and then towards the deep.
- Saturn in Capricorn builds structures; in Aquarius it questions them. The same rigour, first for raising and then for reviewing.

A NOTE OF HONESTY

Modern astrology assigned Uranus to Aquarius, Neptune to Pisces and Pluto to Scorpio. It is a valid and very widespread tradition, but it breaks the symmetry of the system of seven and complicates the bodily correspondences. The classical scheme is used here. If you work with the modern one, everything that follows remains compatible: it just adds one more layer.

THE THIRTY-SIX DECANS

Here begins the part of the system that hardly any popular book explains, and that nevertheless answers the commonest objection made to astrology: «I am not like my sign».

The traditional answer is that a sign is not a uniform block. It occupies thirty degrees of the wheel, and those thirty degrees are divided into three stretches of ten called decans —or, in the old treatises, «faces». Each stretch has a planet at its head that shades the sign without changing its nature. A Taurus of the first face and a Taurus of the third share element, modality and ruler, and behave perceptibly differently.

HOW THEY ARE SHARED OUT

The distribution is not arbitrary: it follows the Chaldean order, the sequence of the seven planets arranged from slowest to fastest in their apparent course. Saturn, Jupiter, Mars, Sun, Venus, Mercury, Moon. The series starts at Mars, which rules the first decan of Aries, and from there it advances one step for each stretch of ten degrees, coming round again when it runs out.

WHY THE SERIES DRIFTS OUT OF STEP

Thirty-six decans and seven planets: 36 is not a multiple of 7. The series does not close, and that is why each sign begins with a planet other than the one it would get if the distribution were regular. It is not an error of transmission: it is the mechanics of the distribution itself, and it is the reason the table has to be learnt and not deduced.

		0° – 10°	10° – 20°	20° – 30°
♈	Aries	♂ Mars	☉ Sun	♀ Venus
♉	Taurus	☿ Mercury	☾ Moon	♄ Saturn
♊	Gemini	♃ Jupiter	♂ Mars	☉ Sun
♋	Cancer	♀ Venus	☿ Mercury	☾ Moon
♌	Leo	♄ Saturn	♃ Jupiter	♂ Mars
♍	Virgo	☉ Sun	♀ Venus	☿ Mercury
♎	Libra	☾ Moon	♄ Saturn	♃ Jupiter
♏	Scorpio	♂ Mars	☉ Sun	♀ Venus
♐	Sagittarius	☿ Mercury	☾ Moon	♄ Saturn
♑	Capricorn	♃ Jupiter	♂ Mars	☉ Sun
♒	Aquarius	♀ Venus	☿ Mercury	☾ Moon
♓	Pisces	♄ Saturn	♃ Jupiter	♂ Mars

PL. 1 The thirty-six decans. Each row is a sign; each column, a stretch of ten degrees with the planet that rules it. The series runs through the Chaldean order without interruption from Aries to Pisces.

HOW TO USE YOUR DECAN

- 1 Locate your sign by your date of birth.
- 2 Inside your sign's chapter, look for the section «The three decans» and find the stretch that contains your date.
- 3 Read the general description of the sign and then the shading of the decan. The first gives you the material; the second, the finish.
- 4 If your date falls on the boundary of two stretches —the exact day of the change— read both. The border is real but it is not a partition wall: those born on it usually recognise themselves in both.

AN HONEST WARNING

The system of decans used here is that of the planetary «faces», the oldest and the most widespread in the Western tradition. Other distributions exist—for instance, assigning each decan to the next sign of the same element—and they are just as legitimate. This book chooses one and keeps it coherent from beginning to end, which is the only way a symbolic system is of any use.

THE GEOMETRY OF THE WHEEL

The signs are not read one at a time. What the tradition observed from the start is that the relative position of two points on the wheel says as much as the points themselves, and that those relations can be measured in degrees. They are the aspects, and they are the grammar by which the zodiac goes from vocabulary to language.

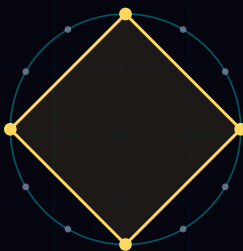
For what this book proposes —working the twelve signs as qualities — the aspects matter for a very practical reason: they explain why some qualities are easy for you to add and others always come into conflict.



OPPOSITION · 180°
Signs facing each other: tension



TRINE · 120°
Same element: fluency



SQUARE · 90°
Same modality: friction



SEXTILE · 60°
Affinity: opportunity

PL. 2 The four major aspects drawn on the wheel of twelve. The geometric figure is not an ornament: it is the relation itself.

THE OPPOSITION · 180°

Two signs facing each other, six cells apart. They share modality and have complementary elements —Fire with Air, Earth with Water—, so that the tension is never one of incompatibility but of direction: both push with the same force towards opposite sides.

The six oppositions of the zodiac form the six axes, and each sign's chapter has its own explained. If you had to keep only one idea from

this chapter, keep this one: your opposite sign is not your enemy, it is the half of your own question that you do not ask.

THE TRINE · 120°

Four cells apart: the same element. It is the most fluent relation on the wheel, and also the most dangerous through comfort. Between signs of the same element there is no translation to do, so there is no obligatory learning either. Aries, Leo and Sagittarius understand one another without explaining themselves — and not one of the three puts the brakes on the other two.

THE SQUARE · 90°

Three cells: the same modality, elements that do not get on. It is the classic friction. Two cardinal signs want to lead at the same time, two fixed ones dig in facing different ways, two mutable ones change plan without telling each other. The tradition calls it a «hard» aspect, and the word is exact: it is the aspect that forces growth because it cannot be resolved by ignoring it.

THE SEXTILE · 60°

Two cells: kindred elements of the same polarity —Fire with Air, Earth with Water—. They get on well but they are not confused with each other, and that is why it is the most productive aspect of the zodiac: there is affinity enough to collaborate and difference enough to bring something. The tradition describes it as an opportunity that has to be

taken; the qualification matters, because the sextile does not act on its own.



THE FOUR ASPECTS IN SUMMARY

OPPOSITION · 180°	6 cells · Same modality, complementary elements · Fertile tension
TRINE · 120°	4 cells · Same element · Fluency, risk of comfort
SQUARE · 90°	3 cells · Same modality, discordant elements · Friction that compels
SEXTILE · 60°	2 cells · Kindred elements · Opportunity if taken
CONJUNCTION · 0°	Same cell · Reinforcement. A sum of intensity, not of shading

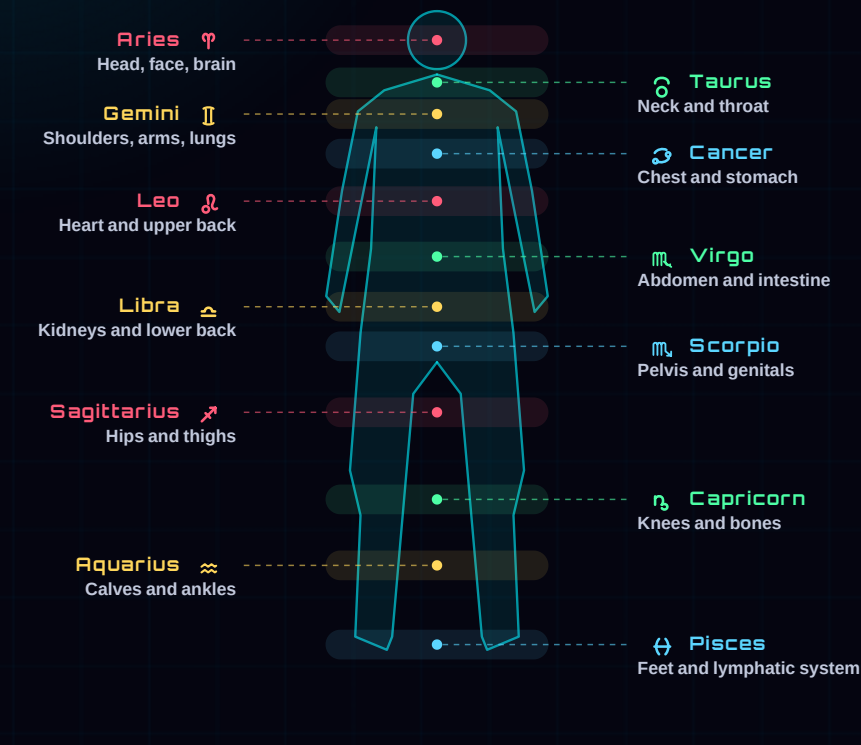
HOW TO MAKE USE OF IT WITH NO BIRTH CHART

This book does not calculate charts. But the aspects can be used without calculating anything: when one of the twelve practices strikes you as unbearably alien, look at what relation it holds to your sign. If it is a square or an opposition, you have the explanation — and also the confirmation that it is precisely the practice that will serve you most.

THE ZODIAC OF THE BODY

There is a tradition within the tradition that deserves a chapter of its own, because it is the oldest and the most forgotten: the distribution of the human body among the twelve signs. The treatises call it melothesia, and it appears in the Greek texts, in the Arab physicians and in practically every European almanac up to the eighteenth century.

The order is of a simplicity that gives one pause: the signs share out the body from head to feet, in the same order in which they occupy the wheel. Aries the head, Pisces the feet, and the remaining ten descending through the body without skipping a stretch.



PL. 3 Melothesia: the twelve signs distributed from the crown of the skull to the sole of the foot, in the order of the wheel. The colour indicates the element.

HOW TO READ THIS PLATE — AND HOW NOT TO

First of all, and this is meant seriously: this is not medicine and it never has been, not even when it was used as such. Melothesia is a mnemonic and symbolic system. It does not diagnose, it does not predict ailments and it must not be used to decide anything about your health. If something hurts, the answer is in a medical consultation.

That said, the plate is good for something, and it is a good deal more useful than it looks: it turns the twelve signs into twelve zones of maintenance. Every chapter of the second part has a section «The body» that develops its sign's zone with care that is common sense —mobility, rest, hydration, postural habit— and not superstition. Going through the twelve signs over a year is, among other things, reviewing the whole body part by part.

THE COMPLETE DISTRIBUTION

ARIES	Head, face, brain · Jaw tension, tension headache
TAURUS	Neck, throat, thyroid · Cervical stiffness
GEMINI	Shoulders, arms, hands, lungs · Short breathing
CANCER	Chest, stomach, diaphragm · Digestion and emotion
LEO	Heart, upper back, circulation · Posture and presence
VIRGO	Abdomen, intestine, spleen · Transit and tolerances
LIBRA	Kidneys, lower back, skin · Water balance
SCORPIO	Pelvis, pelvic floor, reproductive system
SAGITTARIUS	Hips, thighs, liver · Hip mobility
CAPRICORN	Knees, bones, joints, teeth
AQUARIUS	Calves, ankles, venous return
PISCES	Feet, lymphatic system · Drainage and support

THE HIDDEN STRUCTURE OF THE DISTRIBUTION

It is worth looking at the plate twice, because the distribution has an internal coherence that does not leap out. The three Fire signs fall on head, heart and thighs: the three motors of movement. Those of Earth, on neck, abdomen and knees: the three joints that hold the vertical. Those of Air, on shoulders, kidneys and calves: the three points of exchange and of return. And those of Water, on chest, pelvis and feet: the three places where the body keeps what it does not say.

THE AXES WORK IN THE BODY TOO

Each axis of opposite signs joins two zones that in practice work together. Aries and Libra: head and lower back, the two ends of the postural chain. Taurus and Scorpio: throat and pelvis, the body's two diaphragms. Gemini and Sagittarius: shoulders and hips, the two girdles. Cancer and Capricorn: stomach and knees. Leo and Aquarius: heart and venous return. Virgo and Pisces: intestine and lymphatic system. That the tradition got those pairings right with the anatomy available to it is, at the very least, remarkable.

CHAPTER 7

WHY YOU DO NOT RECOGNISE YOURSELF IN YOUR SIGN

It is the commonest objection and the most reasonable. Somebody reads the description of their sun sign, does not recognise themselves at all, and concludes, quite logically, that the system does not work. It deserves a proper answer, because the answer explains how this book is built.

THERE ARE THREE ANSWERS, AND ALL THREE ARE TRUE

- 1 The decan. A sign is thirty degrees and three different faces. The previous chapter develops it: many people who «are not like their sign» recognise themselves immediately on reading their decan.
- 2 The other two points. Traditional astrology never described anybody by their Sun alone. It worked with three pieces: the Sun, the Moon and the Ascendant. The sign the newspapers give is only the first.
- 3 Nobody is a sign. The twelve are in everybody, some developed and others asleep, and that is exactly what makes the twelve-month journey the third part proposes useful.

THE THREE PIECES OF THE CLASSICAL PORTRAIT

SUN, MOON AND ASCENDANT

THE SUN	What you want to be. The project, the direction, the identity you recognise as yours. It is the sign of the date.
THE MOON	How you react when you are not choosing. The emotional habit, the rhythm, what you reach for to calm yourself. It changes sign every two and a half days.
THE ASCENDANT	How you appear and how you enter situations. The front door of the house. It depends on the exact time of birth and changes every two hours.

The distinction is more useful than it looks. It explains, for instance, why somebody describes themselves as reserved and their acquaintances describe them as expansive: the Sun and the Ascendant can point in different directions. Or why a person who is extremely orderly at work is an emotional disaster: the Sun in Earth and the Moon in Water live together in the same body with no trouble at all.

THIS BOOK DOES NOT CALCULATE YOUR CHART

Finding out the Moon and the Ascendant requires the date, the time and the place of birth, and a calculation that does not fit in a book. There are free and reliable calculators everywhere. What this book gives you is the other thing, and it is what almost never gets given: the twelve signs described in enough depth that, once you know which your three are, you know what to do with them.

HOW TO READ THE BOOK ONCE YOU KNOW YOUR THREE SIGNS

- Read your Sun as the chapter of direction: what you are trying to build.
- Read your Moon as the chapter of body and habit: the section «The table» of your Moon usually describes you far better than that of your Sun.
- Read your Ascendant as the chapter of first impressions: if somebody describes you in a way you do not recognise, look there.
- Read the opposite of your Sun as the chapter of unfinished business. It is uncomfortable on purpose.



And if you know none of the three and do not feel like finding out, the book still works. The twelve chapters describe twelve ways of being in the world, and all of them are inside you in some proportion. The third part proposes going through them one a month, and that journey needs no chart: it needs a notebook.

THE ELEVEN KEYS OF EACH SIGN

The twelve chapters of the second part have exactly the same structure. It was done that way on purpose: when all the signs are described with the same keys, the real differences between them become visible and stop depending on the enthusiasm of whoever is writing. It is also the only way the book can be used as a work of reference and not only of reading.

- 1** The seal. The sign's medallion, with its glyph, the sigil of its ruler and the mark of its element. The colours do not decorate: they state the element.
- 2** The entry. Dates, element, modality, polarity, ruler, metal, stone, colour, bodily zone and key word. The classical identity card.
- 3** The symbol. Where the image comes from and what it contains. The symbol is no ornament: it is the compressed form of everything else.
- 4** The strength. What the sign does well when it is at its best.
- 5** The shadow. The same quality taken to excess or to deficiency. It is never a different trait: it is always the strength overflowing.
- 6** The axis. The opposite sign and the question the two of them share. It is the key that discomfits most and the one that yields most.
- 7** The three decans. The thirty degrees divided into three faces, with the dates and the planet of each. Here is the explanation of why

many people do not recognise themselves in the general description.

- 8 The body. The zone the tradition assigns to the sign and the care that actually belongs to it.
- 9 The table. Foods and habits akin to its temperament, in terms of compensation and not of superstition.
- 10 The practice. A concrete four-week exercise for developing the sign's quality, whether or not it is your sun sign.
- 11 Relations and the month's work. Which temperaments it fits with effortlessly and with which ones translation is needed; and three questions for the notebook, which are the part that really changes something.

ON «THE TABLE»

Each sign's food section does not claim that your date of birth determines what you should eat. What it does is more reasonable: every temperament has recognisable tendencies —whoever runs fast tends to eat fast, whoever is constant tends to repeat the same dish for years— and those tendencies can indeed be compensated for. They are recommendations of nutritional common sense applied to each sign's pattern, and in no case an individualised dietary plan.

NO SECTION IS A VERDICT

It is worth repeating before entering the twelve chapters: what follows describes tendencies, not destinies. If on reading your sign you find a shadow you recognise, that is useful information. If you find one you do not recognise, do not force it: the system is a mirror, and a mirror that gives nothing back is simply not pointed there.

THE ESSENTIAL DIGNITIES

Here begins the part of the classical system that modern popularisation has let drop almost entirely, and not out of bad faith: because it is arid, it is learnt with a table in front of you and it does not fit in a magazine horoscope. It is also the part that turns the zodiac into a system with rules instead of a collection of descriptions.

The idea is simple. A planet does not behave the same way in all twelve signs. In some it is on its own ground and operates easily; in others it works uncomfortably, against its own nature. The tradition fixed four degrees of that comfort and gave them names.

THE FOUR DIGNITIES

DOMICILE	The planet is in the sign it rules. At home: it does what it knows how to do with no resistance.
EXALTATION	It is in the sign where the tradition says it is honoured. It yields more than its due, and at an exact degree —not throughout the whole sign—.
DETRIMENT	It is in the sign opposite the one it rules. It works against the grain of its nature and it costs it twice as much.
FALL	It is in the sign opposite its exaltation. It is neither honoured nor attended to.

		DOMICILE	EXALTS	DETRIMENT	FALL
	Aries		 19°		 21°
	Taurus		 3°		—
	Gemini		—		—
	Cancer		 15°		 28°
	Leo		—		—
	Virgo		 15°		 27°
	Libra		 21°		 19°
	Scorpio		—		 3°
	Sagittarius		—		—
	Capricorn		 28°		 15°
	Aquarius		—		—
	Pisces		 27°		 15°

PL. 8 The four dignities sign by sign. With the exact degree where each exaltation and each fall lands. The dashes are not gaps left by oversight: there are signs that house no exaltation at all.

TWO COLUMNS ARE DATA AND TWO ARE DEDUCED

It is worth seeing the mechanics, because they explain why the table is coherent and not an arbitrary catalogue. The domiciles and the exaltations are what the tradition fixes: they have to be learnt. Detriment and fall do not have to be learnt, because they come out on their own — a planet's detriment is always in the sign opposite its

domicile, and its fall in the one opposite its exaltation. Half the table is deduction.

A DETAIL THAT IS HARDLY EVER MENTIONED

The exaltations carry an exact degree: the Sun at 19 Aries, the Moon at 3 Taurus, Jupiter at 15 Cancer, Mercury at 15 Virgo, Saturn at 21 Libra, Mars at 28 Capricorn and Venus at 27 Pisces. Seven planets, seven degrees, seven signs. The remaining five signs —Gemini, Leo, Scorpio, Sagittarius and Aquarius— house no exaltation at all, and that asymmetry is original: the tradition never filled it in.

WHAT THIS IS FOR WITH NO BIRTH CHART

For reading the book with more precision, and for one very concrete thing. When the second part says that Mars in Aries attacks head-on and in Scorpio persists in silence, that difference is not literary: Mars rules both signs, but one is diurnal and the other nocturnal. And when it says that Saturn in Libra builds agreements, it is because it is exalted there — the same Saturn that in Aries, its fall, knows how to do nothing but put on the brakes.

- Mars is in domicile in Aries and Scorpio, in detriment in Taurus and Libra, exalted at 28 Capricorn and fallen at 28 Cancer.
- Venus is in domicile in Taurus and Libra, in detriment in Aries and Scorpio, exalted at 27 Pisces and fallen at 27 Virgo.
- Mercury is the only one with domicile and exaltation in the same sign —Virgo— and that is why Virgo is the more mercurial of the two

signs it rules.

- Saturn rules Capricorn and Aquarius, and is exalted in Libra: rigour finds its best version in the sign of balance, which is one of the finest statements in the whole system.

CHAPTER 10

THE TERMS: THE MOST FORGOTTEN TABLE

If the previous chapter recovered a table that is seldom printed, this one recovers one that has disappeared almost entirely from popular writing — and it is probably the most sophisticated piece of the classical system.

The tradition did not stop at dividing each sign into three decans of ten degrees. It made a second division, finer and deliberately irregular: five stretches per sign, of unequal length, one for each planet except the luminaries. They are called terms, or bounds, or confines depending on the translation; in Greek, horoi.

	0°	5°	10°	15°	20°	25°	30°
♈ Aries	1	♀	♄	♂	♅		
♉ Taurus	♀	♄	1	♅	♂		
♊ Gemini	♄	1	♀	♂	♅		
♋ Cancer	♂	♀	♄	1	♅		
♌ Leo	1	♀	♅	♄	♂		
♍ Virgo	♄	♀	1	♂	♅		
♎ Libra	♅	♄	1	♀	♂		
♏ Scorpio	♂	♀	♄	1	♅		
♐ Sagittarius	1	♀	♄	♅	♂		
♑ Capricorn	♄	1	♀	♅	♂		
♒ Aquarius	♄	♀	1	♂	♅		
♓ Pisces	♀	1	♄	♅	♂	♅	

FIVE UNEQUAL STRETCHES · THIRTY EXACT DEGREES

PL. 9 The sixty terms. Each bar is the thirty degrees of a sign split into five unequal stretches; the length drawn is its number of degrees, so the plate can be measured with a ruler.

WHAT MAKES THIS TABLE SPECIAL

- It is irregular on purpose. The decans are three equal stretches of ten degrees; the terms are five stretches running from two to twelve degrees. The irregularity is not carelessness: it is information.

- Only five planets take part. The Sun and the Moon are left out of the distribution of terms, just as they are left out of the double rulership. The luminaries are not subdivided.
- Each row adds up to exactly thirty. It is the only table in this book that can be verified arithmetically, and that is why the ones on these pages are calculated and checked instead of copied.
- The planet that opens each sign makes sense: Jupiter opens Aries, Venus opens Taurus, Mercury opens Gemini, Mars opens Cancer. It is not the sign's ruler, and that mismatch is the part the ancients argued about most.

THE TWO DISTRIBUTIONS THAT REACHED US

There are two tables of terms in the tradition: the Egyptian, which is the one this book uses and the older, and Ptolemy's, which corrected it to make it more regular. Ptolemy declared that the Egyptian one followed «no natural order» and proposed his own. The Egyptian one outlived him and is the one the Arab and medieval astrologers went on using. It is chosen here for that reason and because it is the one that appears in more manuscripts.

HOW IT IS USED

- 1 Locate the exact degree you are interested in within the sign. If you are working only with your sun sign, your degree is roughly the number of days elapsed since the sign began.
- 2 Look on the plate to see which stretch that degree falls in.

- 3 The planet of that stretch is the finest shading the classical system offers on your position. It is read over the decan, which is read over the sign: three layers, from the coarsest to the finest.

AN EXAMPLE, SO THAT IT DOES NOT STAY ABSTRACT

Somebody born on 12 April is in Aries, third decan ruled by Venus, and their degree —22 or 23 Aries— falls in the term of Mars. Aries of Venus with a term of Mars: the impulse that seeks company and that, in the last stretch, recovers its edge. No other system of twelve categories gives that level of detail.

THE TWENTY-EIGHT MANSIONS OF THE MOON

A second zodiac, parallel to the one of twelve and considerably older in its logic: the one built by following the Moon instead of the Sun.

The reasoning is of a notable elegance. The Moon takes some twenty-seven and a third days to go right round the sky with respect to the stars. If you want one sign per night, you need twenty-eight divisions, not twelve. And out of that comes the system called *manāzil* in Arabic —the stations or lodgings of the Moon—, which has its equivalent in India in the *nakshatras* and which circulated in Europe until the Renaissance in the treatises of correspondences.

THE EXACT ARITHMETIC

THE DIVISION INTO TWENTY-EIGHT

DEGREES PER MANSION	$360 \div 28 = 12^\circ 51' 25,7''$
MANSIONS PER SIGN	2 and $\frac{1}{3}$ · no mansion coincides with a sign
THE MOON'S CYCLE	27.32 sidereal days · hence the 28 lodgings
FIRST MANSION	It begins at 0° Aries, just like the solar zodiac
MISMATCH WITH THE TWELVE	It is deliberate: they are two different grids on the same circle

That mismatch is the interesting part. Since 28 does not divide 12, the two grids never fit: each mansion straddles degrees of different signs. Whoever works with both gets a cross-reading far finer than with one alone — and whoever tries to make them agree will waste their time, because they are not made to agree.

WHY THIS BOOK DOES NOT GIVE THE LIST OF NAMES

And it is worth explaining, because it is the first thing people miss. The twenty-eight mansions have names in at least three traditions — Indian nakshatras, Arabic manāzil and the latinised names of the European manuscripts— and the three lists do not agree: not on the stars that anchor each mansion, not on where the first one begins, not on the transcription of the names, which in the Latin manuscripts appear mangled in a thousand ways. To give one list as though it were THE list would be to invent an authority that does not exist. The division, which is firm, is given, and where the disagreement lies is stated.

WHAT CAN BE USED TODAY

The structure, which is what really serves. Twenty-eight stretches of almost thirteen degrees, travelled by the Moon at a rate of one a night, give a calendar of twenty-eight days that repeats thirteen times a year. It is a temporal frame finer than the month and coarser than the day.

- 1 Begin on any night and number twenty-eight consecutive days.
- 2 Assign each day one single thing to observe. One, not a list.

- 3 When you close the twenty-eight, reread. What appears is not a lunar pattern: it is a pattern of yours, visible because you have measured it with a constant grid.
- 4 Start again. Thirteen times a year, and at the end you have a year of observation in stretches comparable with one another.

AND THE USUAL HONESTY

There is no evidence that the Moon's position with respect to the stars influences anything of what is proposed for observation here. The value of the twenty-eight mansions in this book is that of any regular grid: it allows comparison. It is exactly the same value a sheet of squared paper has, and that is not little.

THE ZODIAC THAT SHIFTED

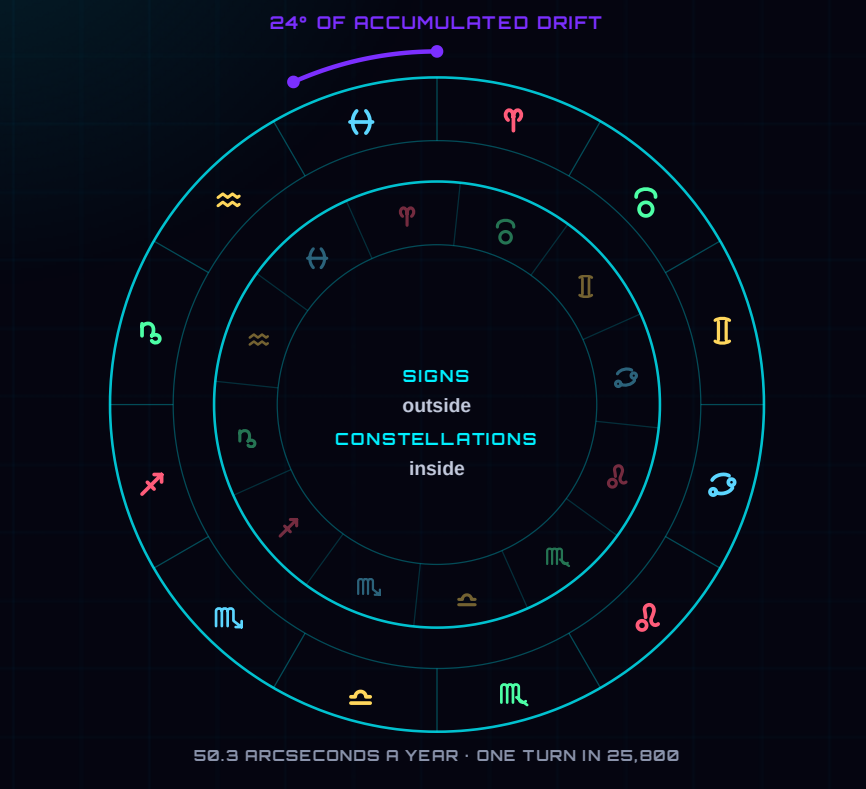
This chapter tackles the most serious objection that can be made to astrology, the only purely factual one, and it does so head-on because dodging it would be dishonest and because the answer is more interesting than the objection.

THE FACT

The Earth does not turn on a fixed axis. Its axis describes an extremely slow cone, and as a consequence the point where the Sun crosses the celestial equator in spring—the vernal point, the zero of the zodiac— shifts backwards around the circle. The phenomenon is called the precession of the equinoxes, Hipparchus of Nicaea described it around 130 before our era, and its figures are as follows.

THE NUMBERS, WHICH ARE NOT IN DISPUTE

SPEED	About 50.3 arcseconds a year
ONE DEGREE	Every 71 and a half years, approximately
COMPLETE CYCLE	About 25,800 years
SINCE PTOLEMY	About 24 degrees accumulated since the second century
CONSEQUENCE	The sign of Aries no longer coincides with the constellation of Aries



PL. 10 Two grids on the same circle: outside, the twelve signs where the tradition fixed them; inside, the constellations of the same name, shifted twenty-four degrees by precession. The gap between the two is this chapter's datum.

WHAT THIS MEANS, SAID PLAINLY

That when somebody says «I'm an Aries» they are not saying the Sun was in front of the constellation of Aries on the day they were born. It was in front of Pisces. The sign and the constellation share a name and no longer share a place.

THE TWO ANSWERS THAT EXIST, AND BOTH ARE LEGITIMATE

TROPICAL ZODIAC AND SIDEREAL ZODIAC

TROPICAL	It counts from the spring equinox, which is a seasonal fact. 0° Aries is «the day spring begins», not «the constellation of Aries». It is the one Western astrology uses and the one this book uses.
SIDEREAL	It counts from the stars and corrects the drift. It is the one Indian astrology uses, and it is astronomically more literal. The difference between the two is called the ayanamsa and today it is worth about 24 degrees.

That two incompatible zodiacs should exist and that both traditions should have been working with their own for centuries says something important about what kind of system this is. If it measured a physical influence of the stars, one of the two would have to be wrong and it would be verifiable which. Since it is a symbolic system of classification, both work equally well inside their own rules — and that, more than a defence, is a description.

THIS BOOK'S POSITION

The tropical zodiac is used, and why is stated: because what this book does with the twelve signs is a calendar of temperament anchored in the seasons, and the cycle of the seasons is real, verifiable and has not shifted. Aries is the impulse that breaks winter; that goes on happening every March regardless of which stars lie behind it. If somebody tells you that precession «refutes» astrology, they have refuted a version no serious astrologer has held since Ptolemy — and if they tell you precession does not matter, they are not telling you the truth either.

THE BONUS, WHICH IS WHAT THE CHAPTER IS WORTH

The famous «signs of the times» —the age of Pisces, the age of Aquarius— come exactly from here. Since the vernal point moves back one sign every 2,150 years approximately (25,800 divided by 12), the constellation housing the spring equinox changes every two millennia. Hence the age of Aries, that of Pisces and that of Aquarius. The arithmetic is impeccable; the exact dates of the changes are not, because the constellations do not have equal borders and every author puts the limit where it suits them. When you read a very precise date for the beginning of the age of Aquarius, you already know somebody has chosen a border and not told you.

SECT: DAY CHARTS AND NIGHT CHARTS

 ne last recovered piece, brief and among those that change the reading most: the doctrine of sect, which Hellenistic astrology used at every turn and which the modern kind abandoned almost entirely.

THE DIVISION

The seven planets are shared between two camps. One diurnal, headed by the Sun; the other nocturnal, headed by the Moon. And membership matters because a planet of the sect that matches the hour of birth operates with more ease than the same planet going against the grain.

THE TWO CAMPS

DIURNAL SECT	Sun · Jupiter · Saturn
NOCTURNAL SECT	Moon · Venus · Mars
MERCURY	With no sect of its own: it takes that of the moment. Diurnal if it rises before the Sun, nocturnal if it rises after.
THE RULE	A day chart if the Sun is above the horizon at birth; a night chart if it is below.

THE PART THAT YIELDS MOST

That Saturn should be diurnal and Mars nocturnal is, at first sight, counter-intuitive: you would expect the opposite of the planet of cold and the planet of heat. The tradition explains it by compensation, and the argument is a good one: Saturn, which is dry and cold to excess, is tempered by the heat of the day; Mars, which is hot and dry to excess, is tempered by the moisture of the night. Each is placed where its excess is corrected.

That logic of compensation is the same one that governs the section «The table» in the twelve sign chapters, and it is no coincidence: it comes from the same place. The whole classical system is built on the idea that what is in excess is balanced by what is lacking, and not on the idea that like attracts like.

HOW TO USE IT WITHOUT CALCULATING ANYTHING

If you know whether you were born by day or by night —and almost everybody does— you already have your sect. The three planets of your camp are the functions that come to you with least effort; those of the opposite camp, the ones that demand conscious work. Cross that with the seven rulers of chapter 3 and you have a reading of your facilities and your frictions that needs no chart and that tends to be uncomfortably recognisable.

CHAPTER 14

ARIES

21 March to 20 April



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Fire
MODALITY	Cardinal
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Mars
METAL	Iron
STONE	Ruby and diamond
COLOUR	Red
BODILY ZONE	Head and face
KEY WORD	I begin

THE SYMBOL

The ram charges. It does not go round, it does not work out the angle, it does not wait for the door to open: it lowers its head and goes. There is all of Aries, and also the reason it is the first sign of the wheel — because before any construction somebody is needed who is willing to strike the first blow.

That the tradition assigns it the head is no accident. Aries arrives head first in both senses: it is the one who thinks fast and the one who gets hit first.

THE STRENGTH

Aries starts what others have been considering for months. It has a clean relationship with action: if something has to be done, it gets done, and deliberation comes afterwards or not at all. That capacity to begin without guarantees is rare and extraordinarily valuable, because hardly any project is born with its conditions assured.

It is also a sign with no duplicity. The frankness of Aries can come across as brusque, but it is seldom treacherous: what it tells you is what it thinks, and what it thinks it thinks now. It holds no grudge because it holds hardly anything — it discharges and moves on.

THE SHADOW

The same speed that lets it begin stops it finishing. Aries accumulates open projects the way others accumulate objects, and confuses initial enthusiasm with the capacity to sustain it. The result is a

record of brilliant beginnings and endings carried out by somebody else.

Its second shadow is irritability. Martial energy that finds no constructive outlet turns into friction with whatever is in front of it, and that wears down relationships Aries genuinely values. It is not aggression: it is energy with no channel.

The third is impatience with other people's pace. Aries reads caution as cowardice when very often it is plain prudence.

THE ARIES-LIBRA AXIS

The axis of the I and the we. Aries knows what it wants and does not know how to consult about it; Libra knows how to consult and does not know what it wants. Each has exactly the half the other lacks.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Aries are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 21–31 MARCH

Mars — Impulse with no filter. It starts what nobody dares to start and gets bored the moment the thing is working.

10° TO 20° · 1–10 APRIL

Sun — Impulse with direction. Here the start wants to be seen, and that — paradoxically — makes it more constant.

20° TO 30° · 11–20 APRIL

Venus — Impulse that looks for company. The most negotiating of the three, and the one that least enjoys winning alone.

THE BODY

The tradition assigns it the head, the face and the brain, and from there come its two real vulnerabilities: jaw tension and headaches of tensional origin. Aries clenches its teeth — literally — and usually finds out when the joint is already hurting.

The care that belongs to it is not resting, because forced repose is unbearable to it. It is channelling. Aries needs intense and regular physical expenditure, not as aesthetics but as a valve: without it, the energy stays inside and turns into tension.

THE TABLE

- Eating slowly, which for Aries is the hardest practice in this book. Putting the cutlery down on the table between mouthfuls.
- Iron from real sources — lean red meat, pulses with vitamin C, dark green leaves — because its ruler calls for it and because it spends a great deal.

- Watching the stimulants. Aries does not need caffeine: it needs less. It is the sign that worst tolerates adding acceleration to the acceleration it already carries.
- An early, light dinner. A racing head does not switch off on a full stomach.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Aries does not learn to wait by reading about waiting. It learns by giving it a number, a deadline and a witness.

- 1 Choose one single thing you have started and not finished. One. Write it on a piece of paper and put it where you will see it every morning.
- 2 Divide it into four parts you can close in a week each. If one part does not fit into a week, divide it again.
- 3 Each week you close one part and tick it off. You start nothing new until the paper is complete — and this is the rule that will hurt.
- 4 At the fourth close, write in the notebook what you felt on finishing something. Aries knows the euphoria of beginning very well and the satisfaction of ending very little.

RELATIONS

- With Leo and Sagittarius, its companions in Fire: they understand one another without explaining themselves, though nobody puts the brakes on anybody.

- With Libra, its opposite sign: the attraction is real and so is the lesson. Libra teaches it to consider the other before moving.
- With Gemini and Aquarius, of Air: they feed its ideas and keep up with its pace.
- With Cancer and Capricorn there is translation to do. All three are cardinal and all three want to lead, each in a different direction.
- With Taurus the friction is one of pure pace: one accelerates, the other digs in. It works well when each recognises that the other has the piece they are missing.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I started this month and what have I finished? Write the two lists and compare their length without justifying yourself.
- 2 Where did I spend energy on friction that led nowhere?
- 3 Whom have I hurried this week, and what did that person actually need?

CHAPTER 15

TAURUS

21 April to 21 May



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Earth
MODALITY	Fixed
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Venus
METAL	Copper
STONE	Emerald
COLOUR	Green
BODILY ZONE	Neck, throat and nape
KEY WORD	I sustain

THE SYMBOL

The bull does not charge: it grazes. It is where it is, it occupies its place and it does not leave it because somebody asks it to. Its strength is not explosive like that of Aries — it is endurance, and that is why Taurus wins almost every long war.

The throat as the sign's zone joins two things Taurus holds together: the voice and taste. It is the sign of the senses and of the word that is kept.

THE STRENGTH

Taurus finishes. It is its great virtue and the most undervalued in the zodiac: where others lose interest, Taurus goes on, and on, and finishes. Constancy does not shine, but it is the only thing that turns a plan into a result.

It also has a capacity for enjoyment no other sign matches. Taurus knows how to be in food, in the body, in rest, in calm. In an age that confuses speed with life, that capacity is a serious advantage and not a weakness.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is inertia. The same stability that lets it sustain what is good makes it sustain what no longer serves — a job, a relationship, an empty routine — long after it knows. Taurus does not resist change out of fear: it resists because changing costs energy and it administers energy with avarice.

The second shadow is possession. Taurus associates worth with having, and that reflex extends to people more easily than it admits.

The third is comfort as a ceiling. When Taurus is at ease it stops growing, and it can spend years comfortable in something it has outgrown.

THE TAURUS-SCORPIO AXIS

The axis of what is conserved and what is transformed. Taurus keeps; Scorpio burns. Both speak of worth: one measures it in permanence and the other in intensity.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Taurus are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 21–30 APRIL	Mercury — Constancy with curiosity. A Taurus that asks questions too: the most practical and the most resourceful of the three.
10° TO 20° · 1–11 MAY	Moon — Constancy as a refuge. The most domestic, the most attached to the known and the one who takes moving house worst.
20° TO 30° · 12–21 MAY	Saturn — Constancy made structure. Nobody takes longer to get going and, once under way, there is no stopping it.

THE BODY

Neck, throat and thyroid are its territory, and cervical tension its commonest complaint. Taurus loads its shoulders: it literally raises them and keeps them up, and ends up with a stiff nape having done nothing but hold out.

Its other point is metabolic. Taurus tends towards slow digestion and towards settling at a weight that goes up very slowly and comes down more slowly still. It is not a problem of will: it is that its body conserves by design.

What works for it is daily movement, moderate and sustained — walking, swimming, carrying weight— rather than heroic and sporadic sessions. Taurus responds extraordinarily well to constancy because constancy is its language.

THE TABLE

- Cervical and shoulder mobility every day, even if only three minutes. It is its non-negotiable maintenance.
- Breaking the monotony of the plate. Taurus eats the same thing for years; introducing one new vegetable a week brings it more than it seems.
- Watching salt and added sugar, which are its two sensory weaknesses.
- Eating sitting down, with no screen and no hurry — Taurus already does this well, and it is worth telling it so.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Taurus does not need to learn to sustain. It needs to learn to let go, and for that an uncomfortable exercise with a date is required.

- 1 Write down three things you are sustaining that no longer serve you. An object, a habit and a commitment.
- 2 Choose the smallest of the three and let it go this week. Only the smallest: it is not a purge, it is a training.
- 3 Write down what you feared losing when you let it go and what you actually lost. They almost never coincide, and finding that out is the point of the exercise.
- 4 Repeat with the second the following month. The third can wait a year: Taurus is not transformed by shoving.

RELATIONS

- With Virgo and Capricorn, its companions in Earth: they recognise one another and build together with no need to discuss it.
- With Scorpio, its opposite sign: the attraction is magnetic and so is the collision. Two fixed signs that do not give way.
- With Cancer and Pisces, of Water: the fit is natural. Taurus gives ground, Water gives depth.
- With Aries and Sagittarius the pace has to be translated. They go, it arrives.
- With Aquarius the distance is real: one values what has been tested, the other what is new for the fact of being new.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What am I sustaining out of habit and not out of decision?
- 2 When was the last time I did something for the first time?
- 3 Did I confuse being comfortable with being well this week?

CHAPTER 16

GEMINI

22 May to 21 June



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Air
MODALITY	Mutable
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Mercury
METAL	Quicksilver
STONE	Agate
COLOUR	Yellow
BODILY ZONE	Arms, hands and lungs
KEY WORD	I connect

THE SYMBOL

Two figures, not one. The symbol of Gemini is not a double being by whim: it is the exact representation of a mind that is always in two places, seeing the matter and seeing itself see the matter.

The arms and hands as the sign's zone point to the same thing: Gemini is the one who takes, shows, points, writes and lets go. Its relationship with the world goes through what it can handle and name.

THE STRENGTH

Gemini understands quickly and explains better. It has a capacity for translation —between disciplines, between people, between levels of complexity— that makes it the piece which makes groups work where nobody understands anybody.

Its curiosity is genuine and without hierarchies: it is interested in quantum physics and it is interested in the gossip on the doorstep, and in both cases for the same reason. That breadth keeps it mentally young for decades.

THE SHADOW

Dispersal is its obvious shadow. Gemini begins seven conversations, opens eleven tabs and ends the day with the exact sensation of having done nothing, because it has indeed gone deep into nothing.

The second is superficiality as a strategy. Gemini can talk about anything for ten minutes, and soon discovers that this is enough to look

competent. The shortcut works so well that it can spend a lifetime without learning anything thoroughly.

The third is evasion through words. When something hurts, Gemini recounts it, analyses it, turns it into an anecdote — and so manages not to feel it.

THE GEMINI-SAGITTARIUS AXIS

The axis of the datum and of meaning. Gemini accumulates information and Sagittarius asks what it means. Without Gemini, Sagittarius preaches without knowing; without Sagittarius, Gemini knows without knowing what for.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Gemini are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 22 MAY–1 JUNE	Jupiter — Curiosity with a horizon: it wants to know everything about everything. The greatest traveller, with the head as well.
10° TO 20° · 2–11 JUNE	Mars — Curiosity sharpened: it checks, argues, provokes. The most incisive and the one who makes the most enemies without meaning to.
20° TO 30° · 12–21 JUNE	Sun — Curiosity with a voice of its own. Here the word stops being a game and becomes a trade.

THE BODY

Lungs and nervous system. Gemini is the sign that breathes badly: short, high, fast, with the chest and not with the abdomen, because its mind runs ahead of its body almost all the time.

Its other vulnerability is overstimulation. Gemini is not exhausted by physical effort, it is exhausted by inputs of information, and it mistakes that for general tiredness. Gemini's insomnia is the insomnia of a mind left switched on.

What works for it is any practice that anchors attention in the body: diaphragmatic breathing, activities that demand coordination — climbing, dance, martial arts— and deliberate silence, which for it is the hardest exercise of all.

THE TABLE

- Regular meals. Gemini skips meals through distraction and then makes do with whatever is around, which is never the best thing.

- Magnesium and omega-3, which are the two nutrients most closely related to the nervous system and cognitive function.
- Less caffeine and more water. Mild dehydration affects its concentration more than it believes.
- Eating with no screen and no conversation at least once a day. For Gemini it is an exercise, not a meal.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Gemini does not need more information. It needs depth, and depth is only trained by repeating.

- 1 Choose one single subject. One that genuinely interests you and about which you know little.
- 2 Give it twenty minutes a day for four weeks. The same subject, the same twenty minutes. Without changing.
- 3 Each week write a page about what you have learnt — by hand, looking nothing up while you write. Writing from memory is what reveals whether you know or merely recognise.
- 4 At the end of the month, explain it to somebody for ten minutes with no notes. That is where the difference between having read and having learnt will show.

RELATIONS

- With Libra and Aquarius, its companions in Air: endless conversation and no need to justify oneself.

- With Sagittarius, its opposite sign: both are mutable and curious, but Sagittarius looks for meaning where Gemini looks for data. They complement each other well.
- With Aries and Leo, of Fire: they give direction to its dispersal.
- With Virgo there is kinship—they share a ruler—and friction too: the same intelligence, one expanding and the other refining.
- With Taurus, Cancer and Pisces both speed and emotional depth have to be translated. Gemini talks about what they feel.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I gone deep into this month, and what have I only nibbled at?
- 2 What have I recounted this week so as not to have to feel it?
- 3 How much time have I spent in silence, with no screen and no conversation?

CHAPTER 17

CANCER

22 June to 22 July



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Water
MODALITY	Cardinal
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Moon
METAL	Silver
STONE	Pearl and moonstone
COLOUR	Silver
BODILY ZONE	Stomach and chest
KEY WORD	I protect

THE SYMBOL

The crab carries its house on its back and moves sideways. Both things describe Cancer precisely: it needs a refuge of its own in order to function, and it seldom goes straight at something when it genuinely matters to it.

The shell hides a soft body, and that is the key to the sign. Cancer's hardness is always external and always defensive. Underneath there is a sensitivity it protects because it knows it is real.

THE STRENGTH

Cancer holds other people up. It has an emotional radar that picks up the state of a room before anybody speaks, and a capacity for care that creates the most lasting bonds in the zodiac. Where there is a Cancer, there is somebody remembering what matters to you.

It is besides the sign with the best emotional memory. It remembers how it felt, not only what happened, and that memory gives it an understanding of people that analytical intelligence never reaches.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is withdrawal. When something wounds it, Cancer goes into its shell and from inside reads the silence as confirmation that it was right to retreat. The mechanism feeds itself.

The second is care that comes with a bill. Cancer gives a great deal, and sometimes expects a reciprocity it has never asked for aloud — and

it resents it when it does not come. Silent resentment is its most habitual form of harm.

The third is living in the past. The same memory that gives it depths ties it to grievances from years ago that it still feels in the present tense.

THE CANCER-CAPRICORN AXIS

The axis of the home and the world. Cancer builds inwards and Capricorn outwards. Both are building the same thing: a place to be safe in.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Cancer are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 22 JUNE–2 JULY	Venus — Sensitivity that cares and makes beautiful. The most welcoming in the whole zodiac.
10° TO 20° · 3–12 JULY	Mercury — Sensitivity that explains itself. It puts words to what it feels, which is very rare in a Water sign.
20° TO 30° · 13–22 JULY	Moon — Sensitivity undiluted. The most intuitive, and the most exposed to its own tide.

THE BODY

Stomach and digestive system, and here the classical correspondence coincides with something physiology recognises: Cancer somatises in the stomach. Emotional tension turns into heavy digestion, acidity or a knot.

Its other point is retention. Cancer is the lunar sign and its body follows cycles: it retains fluid, its weight fluctuates over the month and it gets disheartened by weighing itself on the wrong day.

What works for it is rhythm. Stable meal and sleep times, physical activity in water or gentle and continuous, and one rule it finds hard: always measuring itself at the same point of the cycle and not reading fluctuation as failure.

THE TABLE

- Eating in calm surroundings. For Cancer this is no luxury: its digestion depends on its emotional state more than that of any other sign.
- Cutting back on excess salt and ultra-processed food, which aggravate its tendency to retain fluid.
- Watching the relationship between emotion and food. Cancer is the sign that eats for comfort, and recognising that without guilt is the first step.
- Dining two or three hours before sleeping, always. Its stomach does not rest if it is working.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Cancer does not need to harden. It needs to learn to ask aloud, which is a different thing.

- 1 Identify one thing you need from somebody and have never asked for explicitly. Write it down in its exact words.
- 2 Ask for it. With no preamble, without justifying why you deserve it and without wrapping it in a complaint. One sentence.
- 3 Write down what happened: what you feared, what occurred and how the two resembled each other.
- 4 Repeat with a second request the following week. In this exercise Cancer discovers that the rejection it fears hardly ever comes, and that when it does come you survive it.

RELATIONS

- With Scorpio and Pisces, its companions in Water: they understand one another on a level that needs no words.
- With Capricorn, its opposite sign: the home–work axis, refuge–structure. Textbook complements when there is respect.
- With Taurus and Virgo, of Earth: they give it the concrete stability its emotional world needs.
- With Aries and Libra there is translation to do. All three are cardinal; Cancer leads from the bond and that is not always seen as leadership.
- With Gemini and Aquarius the distance is one of temperature: they analyse what Cancer feels, and that can look to it like coldness without

being coldness.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I needed this month and not asked for?
- 2 Which old grievance do I keep giving a present tense to?
- 3 Did I withdraw at any point this week hoping somebody would come and look for me?

CHAPTER 18

LEO

23 July to 22 August



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Fire
MODALITY	Fixed
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Sun
METAL	Gold
STONE	Amber and ruby
COLOUR	Golden
BODILY ZONE	Heart and upper back
KEY WORD	I express

THE SYMBOL

The lion does not chase: it is there. Its authority comes not from movement but from presence, and that is why Leo is the only sign whose symbol needs to do nothing in order to mean what it means.

That its ruler should be the Sun and its zone the heart says the same thing twice: Leo is the centre that gives warmth to what surrounds it. When it works, the whole system turns better. When it goes out, everybody notices.

THE STRENGTH

Leo generates. It has a capacity for giving impetus, encouragement and recognition that lifts whole teams, and a generosity that is real and not calculated: when Leo gives, it gives for real and does not keep count.

It is also the most loyal sign in the zodiac. Once Leo has taken you into its circle, it defends you publicly and unconditionally, even when it costs it. That loyalty is its noblest trait and the least advertised.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is the need for recognition. Leo does admirable things and needs them to be admired, and when recognition does not come it can go from generosity to reproach at a speed that surprises even itself.

The second is pride as a prison. Leo has a genuine difficulty in admitting a mistake in public, and that blockage has cost it more relationships than any real fault.

The third is dramatisation. Leo enlarges what happens to it —not out of lying, but because it lives it large— and that wears down the credibility that matters so much to it.

THE LEO-AQUARIUS AXIS

The axis of the individual and the collective. Leo needs to be somebody and Aquarius needs it not to matter who it is. Neither of the two works on its own.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Leo are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 23 JULY–2
AUGUST

Saturn — Brilliance with discipline. Less showy to begin with and far more lasting.

10° TO 20° · 3–12 AUGUST

Jupiter — Generous brilliance. It gives what it has and multiplies what it touches; the best host on the wheel.

20° TO 30° · 13–22 AUGUST

Mars — Combative brilliance. It needs an adversary to feel at ease, and if there is none it invents one.

THE BODY

Heart, circulatory system and the upper dorsal area. Leo loads its back between the shoulder blades: it is the sign that holds out with its chest forward and pays for the posture.

Its real point of attention is cardiovascular, and not out of superstition: Leo tends towards sustained intensity with no rest and towards not admitting exhaustion until it is obvious. The sign that least allows itself to stop is the one that most needs to.

What works for it is regular and moderate cardiovascular work — not only intense—, strengthening of the upper back to compensate for the posture, and one discipline it finds especially hard: resting before being exhausted.

THE TABLE

- Keeping an eye on blood pressure and the lipid profile from thirty-five onwards. It is the least glamorous piece of advice in this book and the most useful for Leo.
- Cutting back on sodium and on social drinking, which in Leo tends to be considerable.
- Potassium and magnesium: green leaves, banana, avocado, nuts.
- Not eating standing up or between engagements. Leo skips meals to attend to others and then makes do badly and late.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Leo does not need more brilliance. It needs to check that it is still itself with no audience.

- 1 Choose something you do well and normally share. Anything: cooking, training, writing, fixing something.
- 2 Do it for four weeks without telling anybody and without posting it. Not one photo, not one comment.
- 3 Each week write down what you felt at not being able to show it. That is where the information Leo needs appears.
- 4 At the end, decide what part of your satisfaction came from doing and what part from being seen. There is no bad answer; there is an honest one.

RELATIONS

- With Aries and Sagittarius, its companions in Fire: shared energy and no misunderstanding.
- With Aquarius, its opposite sign: the individual–collective axis. Both fixed, both right, and much to learn from each other.
- With Gemini and Libra, of Air: they give it an audience, brilliance and conversation.
- With Taurus and Scorpio there is a clash of fixity: nobody backs down and everybody knows it.
- With Virgo, Cancer and Capricorn the volume has to be translated. Leo expresses what they would rather contain.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I done this month that nobody has seen?
- 2 Where did pride stop me admitting a mistake in time?
- 3 Whom have I given recognition to this week without waiting for my own?

CHAPTER 19

VIRGO

23 August to 22 September



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Earth
MODALITY	Mutable
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Mercury
METAL	Quicksilver
STONE	Jasper and peridot
COLOUR	Ochre
BODILY ZONE	Intestine and digestive system
KEY WORD	I refine

THE SYMBOL

The maiden with the ear of wheat in her hand: the image is one of harvest and of selection. Virgo separates the wheat from the chaff, and that gesture —discriminating, keeping what is of use— is the whole sign.

That it shares a ruler with Gemini and is of Earth explains its character: the same mercurial intelligence, but applied to the concrete and aimed at the useful result instead of at conversation.

THE STRENGTH

Virgo makes things work. It sees the failing detail before it fails and has a capacity for continuous improvement that turns mediocre processes into good ones. Hardly any organisation survives without a Virgo, and hardly any acknowledges it.

It is also the sign most willing to serve without taking centre stage. Virgo works because the work has to be done, not because it is seen doing it, and that functional modesty is rare and valuable.

THE SHADOW

Criticism is its shadow, and it starts inside. Virgo demands of itself a standard it would apply to nobody else and then projects it, and so manages to be dissatisfied with its own work and with everybody's.

The second is paralysis through perfection. Virgo would rather not deliver than deliver something imperfect, and that reflex has cost it whole opportunities.

The third is worry as a habit. Virgo confuses anticipating problems with preventing them, and can spend years mentally solving situations that are not going to happen.

THE VIRGO-PISCES AXIS

The axis of the detail and of the whole. Virgo distinguishes and Pisces dissolves. One heals with precision and the other with presence, and both are needed.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Virgo are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 23 AUGUST–2
SEPTEMBER

Sun — Analysis with a centre. It orders in order to build, not only to correct.

10° TO 20° · 3–12
SEPTEMBER

Venus — Analysis with taste. Here the detail becomes craft: the finest of the three.

20° TO 30° · 13–22
SEPTEMBER

Mercury — Analysis pure. The most precise in the zodiac and the one that wears itself out most on detail.

THE BODY

The intestine, and here the tradition hit the mark in a way that is striking today. Virgo is the digestive sign, and it is the one that most clearly somatises tension in the digestive system: irritable bowel, bloating, intolerances that appear and disappear.

Its second point is bodily hypervigilance. Virgo observes itself a great deal, and that attention—which in the right dose is prevention—easily turns into health anxiety.

What works for it is a stable digestive routine, fibre and fermented foods, and one rule it finds hard to accept: stop looking up every symptom. Virgo needs less information about its body and more trust in it.

THE TABLE

- Fibre and fermented foods daily: it is the sign that benefits most from looking after its microbiota.
- Chewing properly and not eating in a hurry or standing up. Virgo's digestion begins in the mouth and it usually skips that step.
- Avoiding elimination diets based on suspicion. Virgo removes foods with no diagnosis and ends up with a poor diet and a new fear.
- One meal a week with nothing analysed. No macros, no labels, no calculation. It is a therapeutic exercise for this sign.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Virgo does not need to improve anything more. It needs to practise delivering something imperfect and checking that the world does not collapse.

- 1 Choose a task you have been putting off because it is not ready.
- 2 Give it a deadline of one week and deliver it within that deadline, in whatever state it is in. With no final revision.
- 3 Write down what mistake you feared and what real consequence it had. Be literal: what happened, not what could have happened.
- 4 Repeat three more times. By the fourth cycle Virgo usually discovers that eighty per cent delivered on time is worth more than the hundred per cent that never arrives.

RELATIONS

- With Taurus and Capricorn, its companions in Earth: they understand one another in the concrete and in the demand.
- With Pisces, its opposite sign: the form–dissolution axis. Pisces teaches Virgo that not everything can be put in order, and Virgo teaches Pisces that something has to be.
- With Cancer and Scorpio, of Water: a natural fit between care and precision.
- With Gemini there is mercurial kinship and a clash too: one opens, the other closes.

- With Aries, Leo and Sagittarius the standard has to be translated. They improvise where Virgo prepares.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I left undelivered because it was not perfect?
- 2 How many of this month's worries have come true?
- 3 Have I told anybody something they were doing well, or only what they could improve?

CHAPTER 20

LIBRA

23 September to 22 October



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Air
MODALITY	Cardinal
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Venus
METAL	Copper
STONE	Opal and rose quartz
COLOUR	Pink
BODILY ZONE	Kidneys and lower back
KEY WORD	I balance

THE SYMBOL

The scales are the only symbol in the zodiac that is not a living being, and that matters. Libra does not represent a creature with impulses: it represents a function, that of weighing. Its nature is relational from the symbol itself.

The kidney as the sign's zone says the same thing in physiological terms: it is the organ that balances, filters and maintains internal proportion. Libra does with relationships what the kidney does with the blood.

THE STRENGTH

Libra sees both sides, and not as a concession but as real perception. That capacity makes it the natural mediator of the zodiac: it can hold two opposing positions without disqualifying either, which is an extraordinarily scarce ability.

It also has a sense of proportion that applies to everything: to manner, to space, to aesthetics, to the tone of a conversation. Libra knows when something is one thing too many, and that sensitivity makes people comfortable beside it without knowing why.

THE SHADOW

Indecision is its known shadow, but the real mechanism is another: Libra does not hesitate because it does not know, it hesitates because deciding means unbalancing, and unbalancing feels violent to it.

The second shadow is complaisance. Libra gives way to keep the peace and accumulates unspoken concessions, until one day it breaks over something small and nobody understands why.

The third is dependence on the bond. Libra can define itself so much by the relationship it sustains that it loses sight of what it wants, and discovering that late is painful.

THE LIBRA-ARIES AXIS

The axis of the we and the I. Libra asks before moving and sometimes ends up never moving; Aries moves without asking. Health lies at the centre of the axis, not at either end.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Libra are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 23 SEPTEMBER–
3 OCTOBER

Moon — Emotional balance. It perceives the climate of a room before anybody has spoken.

10° TO 20° · 4–13 OCTOBER

Saturn — Balance with judgement. Here the scales stop hesitating and decide.

20° TO 30° · 14–22
OCTOBER

Jupiter — Expansive balance. It mediates, gathers, opens the table and makes room.

THE BODY

Kidneys and lower back. Libra is the sign of postural low back pain and of insufficient hydration, and the two go together more than it seems.

Its other point is tension from unresolved conflict, which literally accumulates in the lower back. Libra puts up with uncomfortable situations rather than break the calm, and the body keeps the count.

What works for it is water —really, two and a half litres— strengthening of the core and the glutes to support the lower back, and learning to have the conflict at the time instead of putting it off. The last of these fixes more backs than any exercise.

THE TABLE

- Hydration by target, not by thirst: Libra does not drink until it is thirsty and by then it is already late.
- Moderating sugar and alcohol, which are its two venusian weaknesses.

- Watching sodium for the sake of renal function, especially if there is a tendency to retain fluid.
- Eating in company when it can. Libra eats better in company, and that is no whim: it eats more slowly and with more pleasure.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Libra does not need more options. It needs to practise deciding and holding to the decision without renegotiating it.

- 1 Every day for four weeks take one small decision in under a minute and without consulting anybody. What you eat, what you watch, which way you go.
- 2 Do not revisit it. Even if you see a better option afterwards, the decision is taken.
- 3 Each week write down one decision you held to and one it cost you not to reopen.
- 4 In the fourth week, choose a big decision you have been putting off and apply the same procedure to it: a short deadline, no consulting, no revisiting.

RELATIONS

- With Gemini and Aquarius, its companions in Air: they understand and stimulate each other effortlessly.
- With Aries, its opposite sign: the I–you axis in its pure state. The tension is constant and the lesson mutual.

- With Leo and Sagittarius, of Fire: they give it the decisiveness it finds hard.
- With Cancer and Capricorn there is translation to do: three cardinal signs wanting to lead in different directions.
- With Virgo and Pisces the difference is one of criterion: one weighs, another refines and another dissolves.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What decision have I put off this month and what has putting it off cost me?
- 2 Where have I given way without saying so, and how much has piled up?
- 3 What do I want, apart from what the person in front of me wants?

CHAPTER 21

SCORPIO

23 October to 22 November



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Water
MODALITY	Fixed
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Mars
METAL	Iron
STONE	Garnet and obsidian
COLOUR	Dark garnet
BODILY ZONE	Reproductive and excretory systems
KEY WORD	I transform

THE SYMBOL

The scorpion does not fight head-on: it waits, and strikes once where it matters. It is the same Mars as in Aries, but underground: where Aries charges in plain sight, Scorpio calculates in silence.

The tradition assigns Scorpio the zone of generation and elimination, and not out of prurience: they are the two functions where the body creates and destroys. Scorpio is the sign of what dies so that something may be born.

THE STRENGTH

Scorpio sees what is hidden. It has a perception of other people's motives that is uncomfortable for how accurate it is, and a tolerance for unpleasant truth that no other sign matches: where everybody else looks away, Scorpio looks.

It is also the sign with the greatest capacity for regeneration. Scorpio goes through crises that would sink anybody and comes out different, not damaged. Its relationship with loss is one of transformation, not of resistance.

THE SHADOW

Control is its central shadow. Scorpio has learnt that knowing is protecting itself, and from there to watching, checking and withholding information is a short step that it takes easily.

The second is rancour. Scorpio does not forget, and its memory for a grievance has a precision and a duration that weigh on it too.

The third is secrecy. Scorpio asks for a transparency it does not give, and justifies the asymmetry with mistrust. It is the sign that demands keys and does not hand over its own.

THE SCORPIO-TAURUS AXIS

The axis of what is transformed and what is conserved. Scorpio needs to learn that not everything has to die in order to be reborn, and Taurus that not everything can stay as it is.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Scorpio are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 23 OCTOBER–2
NOVEMBER

Mars — Frontal intensity. The most direct of the three and the one that least disguises what it wants.

10° TO 20° · 3–12
NOVEMBER

Sun — Intensity with a purpose. It transforms for something, not out of habit.

20° TO 30° · 13–22
NOVEMBER

Venus — Intensity bound to another. The most magnetic, and also the most jealous.

THE BODY

Reproductive and excretory systems, and by extension everything to do with elimination. Scorpio is the sign that retains: emotionally and also in the difficulty of releasing accumulated physical tension.

Its real point is the wear of internal intensity. Scorpio does not rest mentally even when the body rests, and that translates into bruxism, unrefreshing sleep and pelvic and lumbar tension.

What works for it is intense physical discharge—it is the sign that benefits most from hard training—combined with relaxation practices that cost it because they mean lowering its guard. Scorpio needs both, and only does the first.

THE TABLE

- Plentiful hydration and fibre, on account of the excretory function that belongs to it.
- Watching alcohol as an anaesthetic. Scorpio drinks to bring the intensity down, and it is the sign most at risk of turning that into a habit.
- Looking after the liver and not taking extreme fasting or punitive diets as a challenge: Scorpio tends towards discipline as punishment.
- Eating with no screens and no work. Scorpio eats while thinking about a problem, and that way it neither rests nor digests.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Scorpio does not need more control. It needs to check that it can show something and remain safe.

- 1 Choose one person you genuinely trust. One.
- 2 Tell them one thing about yourself you would not normally tell. Not the most serious one: one of the middling ones.
- 3 Write down what you feared would happen and what actually happened.
- 4 Repeat once a week through the month, with the same person or with another. The aim is not to open up to everybody: it is to dismantle the belief that showing yourself is the same as being left exposed.

RELATIONS

- With Cancer and Pisces, its companions in Water: shared depth with no explanations.
- With Taurus, its opposite sign: two fixed signs with an intense attraction and a struggle for control that can last years.
- With Virgo and Capricorn, of Earth: an excellent fit between intensity and structure.
- With Leo and Aquarius there is a clash of fixity in its hardest version.
- With Gemini, Libra and Sagittarius depth has to be translated: they lighten what Scorpio needs to look at head-on.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What information have I withheld this month in order to keep control?
- 2 Whom am I still making pay for something that is over?
- 3 What have I asked of others that I am not giving myself?

CHAPTER 22

SAGITTARIUS

23 November to 21 December



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Fire
MODALITY	Mutable
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Jupiter
METAL	Tin
STONE	Topaz and lapis lazuli
COLOUR	Purple
BODILY ZONE	Hips, thighs and liver
KEY WORD	I seek

THE SYMBOL

The centaur aims at the horizon. Half animal and half human, with the bow drawn upwards: Sagittarius is instinct put at the service of a search for meaning. It does not shoot for the sake of shooting; it shoots far.

The hips and thighs as the sign's zone are the motor of movement. Sagittarius is the sign of the journey, and the journey may be geographical, intellectual or spiritual, but it is always a movement towards what it does not know.

THE STRENGTH

Sagittarius widens. Where others see a local problem, it sees the context, and that capacity for giving perspective is its best gift: talking to a Sagittarius when you are stuck makes the blockage look smaller.

It is besides the most honest sign in the zodiac, sometimes brutally so. Sagittarius says what it sees, and although the moment is not always the best, its frankness is a form of respect: it is not handling you.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is flight. When something narrows —a relationship, a job, a difficult conversation— Sagittarius suddenly discovers a fascinating opportunity somewhere else. It calls freedom what is sometimes avoidance.

The second is excess. Jupiter amplifies everything it touches, and in Sagittarius that means too much of everything: food, plans, promises,

opinions.

The third is dogma. The sign that seeks the truth has a curious tendency to believe it has already found it, and then it preaches instead of seeking.

THE SAGITTARIUS-GEMINI AXIS

The axis of meaning and of the datum. Sagittarius sees the whole map and skips the streets; Gemini knows every street and does not know where it is going.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Sagittarius are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 23 NOVEMBER–
2 DECEMBER

Mercury — The search that studies. It needs the datum before the faith.

10° TO 20° · 3–12
DECEMBER

Moon — The search that feels. It believes with the body, not with the argument.

20° TO 30° · 13–21
DECEMBER

Saturn — The search that commits. Here the journey stops being a journey and becomes a path.

THE BODY

Hips, thighs and liver. Sagittarius is the sign with the greatest tendency to injury of the hip joint and the hamstring, and almost always for the same reason: it does a lot, with enthusiasm and without preparing.

The liver, ruled by Jupiter, points to its other issue: Sagittarius is the sign of metabolic excess, of the long lingering at table and the one drink too many.

What works for it is hip mobility before any effort, a gradual progression of loads —the opposite of its instinct— and a more moderate relationship with alcohol. Sagittarius responds very well to training; what fails it is the warm-up.

THE TABLE

- Moderating the quantity. Sagittarius does not eat badly: it eats too much, and generally in company and enjoying itself.
- Looking after the liver: less alcohol, less fried food, more bitter vegetables and water.
- Eating to a schedule even when travelling. It is the sign that eats at any hour and eats anything when it is on the move.
- Fibre and fruit: its digestive transit is grateful for the regularity its life does not have.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Sagittarius does not need more horizon. It needs to find out what is at the bottom of one single thing.

- 1 Choose something you began with enthusiasm and abandoned when it stopped being new.
- 2 Take it up again with a four-week commitment and a written deadline. Only four weeks: it is a span Sagittarius can sustain.
- 3 When the new and fascinating idea appears—it will, around the second week— write it down on a list and do not chase it.
- 4 At the end of the month, read the list of ideas you did not chase. Sagittarius usually discovers that half of them no longer interest it, and that is the whole lesson.

RELATIONS

- With Aries and Leo, its companions in Fire: shared enthusiasm and no brakes.
- With Gemini, its opposite sign: two curious mutable signs, one looking for data and the other for meaning. They complement each other very well.
- With Libra and Aquarius, of Air: conversation of some height and mutual space.
- With Virgo and Pisces there is mutable friction: four different ways of adapting and not one of them alike.

- With Taurus, Cancer and Capricorn the need for roots has to be translated: they have it and Sagittarius reads it as a limit.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I escaped from this month by calling it an opportunity?
- 2 Where did I overstep the line without noticing?
- 3 What have I sustained for more than four weeks in a row?

CHAPTER 23

CAPRICORN

22 December to 20 January



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Earth
MODALITY	Cardinal
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Saturn
METAL	Lead
STONE	Onyx and jet
COLOUR	Grey and black
BODILY ZONE	Knees, bones, skin and teeth
KEY WORD	I build

THE SYMBOL

The mountain goat climbs. It does not run, it does not leap gracefully: it finds the next foothold and uses it, and so it gets where nobody else gets. In some versions of the symbol the lower half is a fish, and that sea tail holds the sign's secret: beneath the climb there is a depth Capricorn seldom shows.

Saturn, its ruler, is the planet of limit and of time. Capricorn is the only sign that understands time as an ally and not as a threat.

THE STRENGTH

Capricorn finishes what it begins and finishes it well. It has a capacity for sustained long-term effort that no other sign matches, and a tolerance for deferred gratification that lets it build things that take years.

It is also the most responsible sign. When Capricorn commits, the commitment is kept, and that absolute reliability is the reason it ends up carrying the weight of almost every group it joins.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is hardness, and it starts with itself. Capricorn demands of itself a performance it will not negotiate even when it is ill, and from there it judges others by a standard nobody asked it for.

The second is the confusion between worth and usefulness. Capricorn feels valuable when it produces, and when it does not produce it feels dispensable. It is the sign's most expensive trap.

The third is isolation. Asking for help looks to it like a form of failing, so it carries the load alone until it cannot carry any more, and then it does not say so either.

THE CAPRICORN-CANCER AXIS

The axis of the world and the home. Capricorn conquers and then does not know how to come home; Cancer stays at home and then asks itself why it conquered nothing.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Capricorn are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 22-31
DECEMBER

Jupiter — Ambition with breadth. It builds large from the first drawing.

10° TO 20° · 1-10 JANUARY

Mars — Ambition that executes. The hardest on itself in the whole zodiac.

20° TO 30° · 11-20
JANUARY

Sun — Ambition that shows itself. It reaches the top and needs that to be seen.

THE BODY

Knees, bones, skin and teeth: all the structures. Capricorn is the sign of the joint that wears out under sustained load and of the stiffness that comes with the years earlier than it should.

Its real issue is chronic wear. Capricorn does not get injured all at once: it wears down over years without complaining, and reaches the doctor when the damage is already established. It is also the sign with the greatest tendency to held tension and to exhaustion by accumulation.

What works for it is mobility and strength —not strength alone—, rest scheduled as part of the plan and not as a reward, and periodic check-ups. Capricorn needs rest to be in the calendar, because if it is not written down it does not exist.

THE TABLE

- Calcium, vitamin D and enough protein: it is the sign of the bone and it is worth taking that literally.
- Collagen and omega-3 for the joint, and water for the tissue.
- Eating sitting down and at the proper time. Capricorn eats while working, and in the long run that is paid for.
- Watching coffee as fuel. Capricorn substitutes stimulant for rest for years on end.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Capricorn does not need to perform more. It needs to check that it is still worth something when it is not producing.

- 1 Block out four periods of three hours in the calendar, one a week, with no productive task at all. Written down, with a time, like a meeting.
- 2 Keep them with the same seriousness with which you keep a work engagement. This is the hard part.
- 3 Each week write down what you felt during those hours. Capricorn usually finds guilt, and naming it is the point.
- 4 In the fourth week, ask for help with something. One concrete thing, from one concrete person. And let them do it their way.

RELATIONS

- With Taurus and Virgo, its companions in Earth: they recognise one another in the effort and in the judgement.
- With Cancer, its opposite sign: the work–home axis. Cancer reminds it that there is something besides building.
- With Scorpio and Pisces, of Water: structure finds depth and vice versa.
- With Aries and Libra there is translation to do: three cardinal signs leading towards different places.
- With Gemini and Sagittarius the distance is one of gravity: they lighten what Capricorn takes seriously.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 What have I done this month that was of no use at all and that I enjoyed?
- 2 Whom have I asked for help?
- 3 How many times have I gone on working while ill or exhausted?

CHAPTER 24

AQUARIUS

21 January to 19 February



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Air
MODALITY	Fixed
POLARITY	Active
RULER	Saturn
METAL	Lead
STONE	Amethyst and sapphire
COLOUR	Electric blue
BODILY ZONE	Ankles and circulatory system
KEY WORD	I understand

THE SYMBOL

The water bearer pours. It is not a water sign—it is of Air—and that apparent contradiction is the key: what Aquarius pours out is not liquid, it is knowledge. It hands out what it has understood, and it hands it out for everybody.

That its classical ruler should be Saturn explains something surprising: Aquarius is not chaotic. It has a rigorous mental structure, only it applies it to questioning existing structures instead of to holding them up.

THE STRENGTH

Aquarius sees what is coming. It has a genuine capacity for thinking outside the inherited frame and for imagining how things might be if they were not as they are, and that vision is what produces the changes everybody later takes for obvious.

It is also the sign with the greatest sense of the collective. Aquarius genuinely cares about what happens to people it does not know, and that capacity for being outraged by somebody else's injustice is its noblest trait.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is emotional distance. Aquarius loves humanity and finds it hard to be present with the person in front of it, and that asymmetry hurts its own people.

The second is automatic rebellion. Aquarius can oppose something simply because it is what is established, and mistake systematic contrariness for thinking for itself.

The third is stubbornness. It is a fixed sign, however unlike one it looks: once Aquarius has decided how things are, arguing with it is exhausting and generally useless.

THE AQUARIUS-LEO AXIS

The axis of the collective and the individual. Aquarius loves humanity and finds the actual neighbour hard; Leo loves the actual neighbour and forgets humanity.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Aquarius are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 21–31 JANUARY

Venus — Amiable independence. It gathers people without letting anybody tie it down.

10° TO 20° · 1–9 FEBRUARY

Mercury — Mental independence. The most brilliant and the most impersonal.

20° TO 30° · 10–19
FEBRUARY

Moon — Independence with a heart. It cares about the group for real, not only about the idea of the group.

THE BODY

Ankles and circulation, in particular venous return. Aquarius is the sign of poor peripheral circulation, of cold extremities and of the ankle that used to turn in youth and is still the weak point.

Its other issue is nervous. Aquarius lives in its head, forgets its body for hours and is then surprised to be exhausted. It is, along with Gemini, the sign that registers its own physical signals worst.

What works for it is activity that moves blood to the extremities — walking, cycling, swimming—, not sitting for hours without moving, and specific ankle and calf work. And something harder: coming down into the body regularly, because it does not come down on its own.

THE TABLE

- Foods that look after circulation: omega-3, red berries, citrus fruit, little salt.
- Eating at set times. Aquarius forgets to eat when something interests it, and is quite capable of discovering at five in the afternoon that it has not had breakfast.

- Hydration and magnesium for nervous function.
- Not turning diet into an ideological position. Aquarius adopts eating patterns out of conviction and sometimes forgets to check whether they agree with it.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Aquarius does not need more ideas. It needs to practise presence with one concrete person.

- 1 Choose somebody close to you. One only.
- 2 Stay with them thirty minutes a week for four weeks, with no screens, no debate of ideas and without solving anything for them. Just being there and listening.
- 3 Do not propose solutions. For Aquarius this is almost impossible and it is the core of the exercise.
- 4 Each week write down what you learnt about that person that you did not know. Aquarius usually discovers that it knew their opinions and not their life.

RELATIONS

- With Gemini and Libra, its companions in Air: immediate understanding and mutual space.
- With Leo, its opposite sign: the collective–individual axis. Two fixed signs with much to teach each other and little willingness to give way.
- With Aries and Sagittarius, of Fire: they share a taste for freedom and movement.

- With Taurus and Scorpio there is a clash of pure fixity.
- With Cancer and Pisces the temperature has to be translated: they feel where Aquarius understands.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 Whom have I listened to this month without trying to fix anything for them?
- 2 Have I opposed something simply because it was what is established?
- 3 How long have I sat without moving, and when did I come down into my body?

CHAPTER 25

PISCES

20 February to 20 March



CORRESPONDENCES

ELEMENT	Water
MODALITY	Mutable
POLARITY	Receptive
RULER	Jupiter
METAL	Tin
STONE	Aquamarine and amethyst
COLOUR	Turquoise
BODILY ZONE	Feet and lymphatic system
KEY WORD	I dissolve

THE SYMBOL

Two fish tied together swimming in opposite directions. The symbol describes the sign's permanent tension: one part goes towards the world and another towards dissolution, and both are joined by the same thread.

Pisces closes the wheel, and that position explains its nature. It is the sign where forms come undone so that the cycle can begin again: that is why its personal boundary is porous and why its compassion has no borders.

THE STRENGTH

Pisces feels what is happening to the other person. It does not deduce it: it feels it, and that direct empathy makes people open up to it without knowing why. It is the sign people tell what they do not tell.

It also has a creative capacity that comes from the same source: with its boundary less firmly drawn, it reaches associations and images that are closed to others. Pisces signs are disproportionately frequent among musicians, poets and therapists, and that is no coincidence.

THE SHADOW

Its shadow is the lack of a boundary. Pisces absorbs the emotional state of whoever is near and ends up not knowing what it feels itself, exhausted by emotions that were not its own.

The second is evasion. When reality presses, Pisces leaves: into fantasy, into sleep, into the substance, into the relationship that will

rescue it. It is the sign with the greatest facility for not being where it is.

The third is victimhood. Pisces can settle into the role of the one who suffers because from there nothing has to be decided, and that refuge is comfortable and corrosive.

THE PISCES-VIRGO AXIS

The axis of the whole and the detail. Pisces feels everything and orders nothing; Virgo orders everything and sometimes misses what it was ordering.

THE THREE DECANS

The thirty degrees of Pisces are not homogeneous. The tradition divides them into three stretches of ten and puts a different planet at the head of each, which shades the sign without changing it. Find your date: if you have never quite recognised yourself in the general description, the explanation is usually here.

THE THREE FACES OF THE SIGN

0° TO 10° · 20 FEBRUARY–1 MARCH	Saturn — Sensitivity with a form. The only one of the three that manages to finish what it imagines.
10° TO 20° · 2–11 MARCH	Jupiter — Generous sensitivity. Compassion that organises itself into work.
20° TO 30° · 12–20 MARCH	Mars — Combative sensitivity. It defends what is fragile, and in that defence it finds its own boundary.

THE BODY

Feet and lymphatic system, the sign's two structures. Pisces has the feet as a real weak point —fungal infections, fasciitis, poor support—and a tendency to retain fluid and to sluggish lymphatic circulation.

Its other point is general sensitivity: to medicines, to alcohol, to caffeine, to surroundings. Pisces reacts to doses others do not react to, and it is as well that it should know.

What works for it is movement in water —where it is at home—, active care of the foot and of footwear, and a structure of set times that does not come naturally but holds it up. Pisces flourishes on routine, however little routine appeals to it.

THE TABLE

- Cutting back on alcohol and sugar in earnest: it is the sign that tolerates them worst.
- Eating at fixed times. Pisces eats when it remembers, and its energy depends on that more than it believes.
- Watching fluid retention: less salt, more water, daily movement.
- Watching caffeine and stimulants, which affect it twice as much as the average.

THE PRACTICE OF THE SIGN

Pisces does not need to feel more. It needs to practise the boundary, and the boundary is trained by saying no.

- 1 Each week for a month, say no to one thing. A request, an invitation, a favour.
- 2 With no long explanation and no apology. «I can't» is a complete sentence.
- 3 Write down what you felt on saying it and what happened afterwards. Pisces almost always discovers that the catastrophe it feared does not happen.
- 4 In the fourth week, say no to something you could indeed do but do not want to. That is the real exercise.

RELATIONS

- With Cancer and Scorpio, its companions in Water: they understand one another on a level that requires no language.
- With Virgo, its opposite sign: the dissolution–form axis. Virgo gives it structure and it gives Virgo permission not to control everything.
- With Taurus and Capricorn, of Earth: they give it the ground its nature does not have.
- With Gemini and Sagittarius there is mutable friction: a great deal of movement and little common direction.
- With Aquarius and Libra the difference is one of register: they think the emotion and Pisces inhabits it.

THE MONTH'S WORK

- 1 Which emotion this month was not mine?
- 2 What did I escape from, and where did I go?

3 What did I say no to, and what actually happened afterwards?

THE YEAR AS A SPIRAL

Here is the use that turns this book into a tool. The proposal is simple to state and demanding to carry out: go through the twelve signs over the course of a year, a month for each, working the practice that belongs to it.

It does not matter what your sun sign is. The twelve describe complete human qualities, and we all have them: some developed by temperament and others atrophied through disuse. The aim of this journey is not to reinforce what you already do well, but to visit for four weeks the quality you handle worst.

HOW IT IS ORGANISED

THE CALENDAR OF THE JOURNEY

MONTH 1 · ARIES	Finishing what was started
MONTH 2 · TAURUS	Letting go of what no longer serves
MONTH 3 · GEMINI	Going deep into one single subject
MONTH 4 · CANCER	Asking aloud
MONTH 5 · LEO	Doing with no audience
MONTH 6 · VIRGO	Delivering imperfect
MONTH 7 · LIBRA	Deciding and holding to it
MONTH 8 · SCORPIO	Showing something of your own
MONTH 9 · SAGITTARIUS	Sustaining four weeks
MONTH 10 · CAPRICORN	Resting without producing
MONTH 11 · AQUARIUS	Being present with somebody
MONTH 12 · PISCES	Saying no

You can begin in whichever zodiacal month corresponds to the date you open the book, or begin with Aries in March so that the journey coincides with the natural cycle. The second option has an advantage: the month's sign is «in the air», and the work leans on the season.

THE THREE RULES OF THE JOURNEY

- 1 One practice a month. Not two. The temptation to speed up is exactly the pattern this method corrects.

- 2 It gets written. The three questions at the end of each sign are answered in writing, by hand, on the last day of the month. Without writing there is no journey: there are good intentions.
- 3 The uncomfortable sign does not get skipped. The sign whose practice strikes you as unnecessary or ridiculous is, almost certainly, the one you most need.

WHAT TO EXPECT

This journey does not change your character, and be wary of any book that promises it will. What it does is more modest and more real: it shows you twelve ways of operating, obliges you to practise the ones you do not use and leaves you a written record of what you observed. At the end of the year you will have twelve pages in your own hand about yourself. That is worth more than anybody else's interpretation.

THE MOON AND ITS EIGHT PHASES

Of the seven classical bodies, the Moon is the only one whose cycle can be followed with the naked eye, with no instruments and no tables. Twenty-nine and a half days, eight recognisable phases, and a correspondence with the rhythm of human work that led almost every known agricultural culture to distribute the tasks of the fields according to its course.

What follows is not a claim about the physical influence of the Moon on plants or on the body — that debate belongs to science and not to this book. It is something different and perfectly usable: a four-week calendar with a different verb in each stretch. Its value does not lie in the Moon: it lies in having a twenty-nine-day structure that repeats without having to be decided.



PL. 7 The eight phases and the verb the tradition associates with each. From left to right: four waxing phases and four waning.

THE CYCLE AS A WORKING STRUCTURE

THE EIGHT STRETCHES AND THEIR TASK

NEW MOON	Sow. You decide and write down what you are going to do. You do not begin yet: you define.
WAXING CRESCENT	Begin. The first concrete movement, however small.
FIRST QUARTER	Decide. The first real obstacle appears and you have to choose how to go on.
WAXING GIBBOUS	Sustain. The boring stretch, and the one that separates the projects that come off from the ones that do not.
FULL MOON	Culminate. You look at what has been done and you show it. Also the stretch in which everything looks more intense than it is.
WANING GIBBOUS	Review. You correct with the information you now have and did not have before.
LAST QUARTER	Release. You take away what is not going to arrive. It is the stretch hardly anybody does.
WANING CRESCENT	Close. You write down what worked and leave the ground clear for the next cycle.

HOW TO USE IT WITH THIS BOOK

- 1 Each month of the twelve-month journey coincides roughly with a lunar cycle. Begin the sign's practice at the new moon and not before.
- 2 The four weeks of the practice fit the four phases: define, begin, sustain, close. The sign's practice is already written in four steps precisely for this reason.

- 3 Write the month's record at the waning moon, not at the full. At the full everything looks more important than it is and the record comes out exaggerated.
- 4 If a month goes out of true on you, do not fix it: write it down. The cycle that breaks tells you more than the one that comes out perfect.

WHAT THE MOON DOES NOT DO

It does not bring on births, it does not alter sleep in any demonstrated way, it does not determine the outcome of a decision and it does not explain anybody's bad temper. The attribution of those effects is cultural, not physical, and this book does not maintain it. What is proposed here is to use a visible and regular cycle as a temporal frame: the same function a diary performs, with the advantage that this one does not have to be wound up.

PLANETARY DAYS AND HOURS

This chapter gathers the most technical and least publicised part of the classical system, and also the part that produces the small astonishment of seeing that an everyday custom hides an ancient mathematical structure. The week you use every day is an astrological artefact, and its names give it away.

THE SEVEN DAYS

EACH DAY AND ITS RULER

MONDAY	Moon · lunes, lundi, Monday. Routine, home, care, memory
TUESDAY	Mars · martes, mardi. Drive, conflict, exercise, decision
WEDNESDAY	Mercury · miércoles, mercredi. Word, paperwork, study
THURSDAY	Jupiter · jueves, jeudi. Expansion, agreement, travel, generosity
FRIDAY	Venus · viernes, vendredi. Bond, enjoyment, art, reconciliation
SATURDAY	Saturn · sábado, Saturday. Limit, order, closing, review
SUNDAY	Sun · domingo, Sunday, dies solis. Centre, rest, identity

The Romance languages keep five of the seven planetary names and replaced the remaining two with Christian terms —the Lord's day and the Hebrew sabbath—; English and the Germanic languages keep all seven, with the planets translated into local gods: Tiw for Mars, Woden for Mercury, Thor for Jupiter, Frigg for Venus. The structure is the same in all of them.

THE QUESTION HARDLY ANYBODY ASKS

Why that order? The planets arranged by slowness run Saturn, Jupiter, Mars, Sun, Venus, Mercury, Moon. But the week runs Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, Saturn, Sun. It does not match, and it is not an arbitrary order: it is an arithmetical consequence of the distribution of the hours.

THE TWENTY-FOUR HOURS

The classical system divides the day into twenty-four planetary hours and assigns a ruler to each, following the Chaldean order in a loop. The first hour of the day belongs to the planet that gives the day its name. And here is where it gets interesting: twenty-four divided by seven gives three, with three left over. So the twenty-fifth hour —the first of the next day— always falls three places further down the Chaldean ladder.

- 1 Start on Sunday, the Sun's day. First hour: Sun.
- 2 Distribute the 24 hours in descending Chaldean order and in a loop: Sun, Venus, Mercury, Moon, Saturn, Jupiter, Mars, Sun, Venus...

- 3 Sunday's 24th hour falls on Mercury. The 25th —the first of Monday— falls on the Moon. And Monday is, indeed, the Moon's day.
- 4 Repeat and the seven days will come out in the exact order of the week: Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, Saturn, Sun. The whole week is contained in a jump of three.

WHAT YOU HAVE JUST SEEN

The seven-day week with those names and in that order is the fossil trace of a system of planetary hours that fell out of use centuries ago. It has survived in the calendar of half the world with hardly anybody knowing where it came from. If you were looking for hidden knowledge in the literal sense —something in plain sight that nobody looks at— this is the most hidden thing in this book.

THE HOURS ARE NOT OF SIXTY MINUTES

A detail most modern tables overlook: the planetary hours are unequal. The day is counted from sunrise to sunset and divided into twelve parts; the night, from sunset to sunrise, into another twelve. In summer the daytime hours are long and the night ones short, and in winter the other way round. Only at the equinoxes do they measure sixty minutes.

- 1 Look up the time of sunrise and sunset for your day and your city.
- 2 Subtract: you get the length of the day. Divide it by twelve and you have the length of one daytime planetary hour.

- 3 The first hour begins at sunrise and belongs to the day's ruler.
- 4 Go on advancing in descending Chaldean order. The thirteenth hour begins at sunset and continues the series without a break.

WHAT THIS IS FOR, HONESTLY

It is no use for predicting anything, and this book is not going to suggest otherwise. It is good for two real things. The first is historical: understanding where the calendar you use came from. The second is practical and quite effective: distributing the week's tasks by symbolic affinity. Putting the difficult conversations on Wednesday, the hard training on Tuesday, the closing of accounts on Saturday and real rest on Sunday has no astral effect whatever — and it works, because any repeated structure works better than deciding each day from scratch.

SUGGESTED WEEKLY DISTRIBUTION

MONDAY · MOON	Planning, tidying the house, cooking for the week
TUESDAY · MARS	Demanding training, tasks you keep putting off, decisions
WEDNESDAY · MERCURY	Writing, studying, paperwork, difficult conversations
THURSDAY · JUPITER	Meetings, proposals, whatever has to be made to grow
FRIDAY · VENUS	People, enjoyment, mending what got broken
SATURDAY · SATURN	Reviewing, throwing out, closing, accounts, maintenance
SUNDAY · SUN	Real rest. No screen and no to-do list

THE TABLE OF THE FOUR TEMPERAMENTS

This chapter is the most practical in the book and also the one that departs furthest from the astrological tradition, so it is as well to say at the outset what it rests on. The classical theory of the temperaments —choleric, melancholic, sanguine, phlegmatic— is the same one that distributes the four elements, and for centuries it was the frame within which food was thought about in Europe. As physiology it is superseded. As a description of behavioural patterns around food it remains surprisingly useful, and it is in that one sense alone that it is used here.

THE LIMIT OF THIS CHAPTER

Nothing that follows is an individualised dietary plan. There is no calculation of requirements, there are no pathologies taken into account and there is no follow-up — the three things that define the work of a registered dietitian. What there is are common-sense habits grouped by behavioural pattern. If you have a medical condition, are pregnant, take medication or want a real plan, that is prescribed by a registered health professional and not by a book.

FIRE · ARIES, LEO, SAGITTARIUS

The pattern is speed. Fire eats fast, eats standing up, skips meals when it is busy and then compensates all at once. It usually tolerates the volume of food well and irregular timing badly, and frequently confuses acceleration with energy.

- The main correction is not what to eat but at what speed. Cutlery down on the table between mouthfuls, and a minimum of twenty minutes per meal.
- A stable timetable before a perfect composition. For this temperament, always eating at the same time yields more than any change of menu.
- Watching the stimulants. It is the pattern that worst tolerates adding caffeine to an activation that comes as standard.
- An early, light dinner: a racing head does not switch off on a full stomach, and sleep is where this temperament loses most.
- Intense and regular physical expenditure. Not as aesthetics: as a valve. With no discharge, the energy turns into tension and the tension into snacking.

EARTH · TAURUS, VIRGO, CAPRICORN

The pattern is repetition. Earth eats well and eats the same: it finds four dishes that work and keeps them up for years. The virtue is enormous —constancy is the variable that weighs most in any dietary habit— and the risk is twofold: monotony of nutrients and difficulty in changing when the body changes.

- Making the most of constancy, which is its real advantage: batch cooking, planned shopping, the same day for the same thing. For this temperament the system comes free.
- Forcing variety inside the structure, not against it. The same meal, a different vegetable or a different pulse each week.
- Fibre and water, which is where it usually falls short: slow transit is this pattern's commonest complaint.
- Moderate daily movement rather than heroic and sporadic sessions. Earth responds extraordinarily well to the sustained because it is its language.
- Reviewing the portion honestly every so often. It is the temperament that adapts best to eating well and notices worst that it is eating too much.

AIR · GEMINI, LIBRA, AQUARIUS

The pattern is disconnection. Air eats while doing something else: reading, talking, in front of a screen. It usually has little awareness of the quantity taken in, forgets whole meals without drama and then snacks all afternoon without registering it as eating.

- Eating with no screen and no reading. For this pattern it is the single intervention with the most effect, and the hardest to accept.
- Structuring the meals: it is the temperament that benefits most from having five defined moments in the day instead of a continuum.
- Watching the snacking, which here is almost always nervous and not hunger. Before snacking, a glass of water and five minutes.

- Attending to protein at every meal: when eating distractedly, it is the macronutrient this pattern skips most easily.
- Breathing and rest. Air tends towards short breathing and late sleep, and both show in the next day's appetite.

WATER · CANCER, SCORPIO, PISCES

The pattern is the link between food and emotion. Water eats to calm itself, associates particular dishes with particular memories and eats less when something weighs on it. It is not a defect of will: it is that in this temperament food performs a real emotional function, and plans that ignore it fail.

- Recognising emotional hunger instead of fighting it. Before eating outside mealtimes, one written question: what am I hungry for?
- Looking after digestion, which is where this pattern registers mood. Smaller and more frequent meals when the stretch is a hard one.
- Not banning the comfort dish: giving it a place. Once a week, conscious and without guilt, works far better than prohibition.
- Cutting back on rescue sugar. It is the temperament that most uses it as an emotional regulator and the one that most feels the slump afterwards.
- Salt, water and sleep in that order of importance. Water retains fluid, and almost always through insufficient rest rather than through diet.



THE TABLE OF THE FOUR CORRECTIONS

A SUMMARY THAT FITS ON THE FRIDGE

FIRE	Corrects SPEED. Eat slowly and at the same time
EARTH	Corrects VARIETY. Same structure, different content
AIR	Corrects ATTENTION. No screen, with set times
WATER	Corrects the MOTIVE. Ask before eating outside mealtimes

AND THE CORRECTION THAT SERVES ALL FOUR

If you are going to take only one thing from this whole chapter, take this: not one of the four corrections talks about what to eat. All four talk about how. It is the part hardly any eating plan addresses and the one that decides whether the rest holds up.

VOCABULARY OF THE ZODIAC

The terms that appear in this book, defined precisely enough to read any other treatise without getting lost. They go in alphabetical order and not in order of appearance: it is a chapter to come back to, not to read straight through.

A - D

ASCENDANT

The sign rising over the eastern horizon at the moment of birth. It changes roughly every two hours and describes the way of appearing and of entering situations. It requires an exact time.

ASPECT

Angular distance between two points on the wheel, measured in degrees. The four major ones are the opposition (180°), the trine (120°), the square (90°) and the sextile (60°).

CHALDEAN (ORDER)

The seven classical planets arranged by apparent slowness: Saturn, Jupiter, Mars, Sun, Venus, Mercury, Moon. It governs the distribution of decans and of planetary hours.

CARDINAL

Modality of the four signs that open a season: Aries, Cancer, Libra, Capricorn. They initiate.

SQUARE

Aspect of 90°. It joins signs of the same modality and discordant elements. Friction that compels growth.

DECAN

Each of the three stretches of ten degrees into which a sign is divided. Also called a «face». Each has a ruling planet of its own.

DIURNAL

Traditional synonym for active polarity: the signs of Fire and Air. Their movement goes from the inside towards the world.

E – M

AXIS

A pair of opposite signs, 180° apart. There are six on the wheel, and each poses a question that its two ends answer by halves.

ELEMENT

Fire, Earth, Air or Water. It describes what a sign's energy is made of. Three signs per element.

FIXED

Modality of the four signs that sustain a season: Taurus, Leo, Scorpio, Aquarius. They maintain.

LUMINARIES

The Sun and the Moon, the only two classical bodies that rule one sign each.

MELOTHESIA

Traditional distribution of the human body among the twelve signs, from head to feet. A symbolic and mnemonic system, never a diagnostic one.

MODALITY

Cardinal, Fixed or Mutable. It describes how a sign's energy moves. Four signs per modality.

MUTABLE

Modality of the four signs that close a season: Gemini, Virgo, Sagittarius, Pisces. They adapt and transform.

N – Z

NOCTURNAL	Traditional synonym for receptive polarity: the signs of Earth and Water. Their movement goes from the world towards the inside.
OPPOSITION	Aspect of 180°. It joins signs of the same modality and complementary elements. Fertile tension, not conflict.
POLARITY	Active or receptive. It alternates sign by sign around the wheel.
RULER	The planet that rules a sign. In the classical system of seven, five planets rule two signs each and the luminaries one.
SEXTILE	Aspect of 60°. It joins signs of kindred elements and the same polarity. An opportunity that has to be taken actively.
SUN SIGN	The sign the Sun occupied on the date of birth. It is the one asked about in ordinary conversation, and only one of the three pieces of the classical portrait.
TRINE	Aspect of 120°. It joins signs of the same element. Fluency, with the risk that comfort prevents learning.
TRIPLICITY	The three signs that share an element. A synonym for trine when speaking of groups and not of angles.

ON WHAT THIS VOCABULARY DOES NOT INCLUDE

The houses, the trans-Saturnian planets, the lunar nodes and the predictive techniques do not appear here. It is not an oversight: this book works deliberately with the system of seven planets and twelve signs, which is closed, coherent and sufficient for everything proposed here. If you go on by yourself, those terms are the next step.

OBSERVATION RECORD

These pages are for writing on. The part of the book that produces results is not the part you read: it is the part you fill in.

STARTING RECORD

BEFORE BEGINNING THE JOURNEY

START DATE

MY SUN SIGN

THE SIGN WHOSE
PRACTICE SEEMS MOST
UNNECESSARY TO ME

THE SIGN WHOSE
PRACTICE I LEAST FEEL
LIKE DOING

WHAT I WANT TO OBSERVE
THIS YEAR

A HINT ABOUT THE TWO MIDDLE QUESTIONS

The sign that seems unnecessary to you and the one you least feel like doing are usually the same, and it is usually the one that works precisely the quality you lack. Write them down now, before you begin, and read them again a year from now.

MONTHLY RECORD

For each month of the journey, write down the same things: the sign, the practice, whether you kept it and what you observed. Four lines a month are enough. What matters is not the length: it is that the record exists and that it is honest.

MONTHLY TEMPLATE

SIGN OF THE MONTH	_____
PRACTICE	_____
WEEKS KEPT	1 · 2 · 3 · 4
WHAT COST ME	_____
WHAT I DISCOVERED	_____

CLOSING THE YEAR

ON FINISHING THE TWELVE MONTHS

THE PRACTICE THAT COST ME MOST	_____
THE PRACTICE THAT SERVED ME MOST	_____
WHAT I AM STILL DOING A YEAR LATER	_____
THE SIGN THAT TURNED OUT TO BE REALLY MINE	_____



That last question is the book's only trick, and it deserves explaining. After a year going through the twelve signs, many readers discover that the quality that transformed them most was not that of their sun sign, but that of another which at the start felt alien to them. It does not mean their sign has been calculated wrongly. It means the zodiac is not a label received at birth, but a repertoire one learns to use.

And with that, the book has done its work.

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